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either), whereupon it Bucks to dislodge its riders into the glade below before returning to its perch here to recover from the fight.

NIGHTMARE ROOK CREATURE 20

UNIQUE CE GARGANTUAN BEAST

Variant roc (*Pathfinder Bestiary* 281)

Perception +38; low-light vision

Languages Aklo, Common, Sylvan

Skills Acrobatics +34, Athletics +38, Deception +35, Intimidation +35

Str +10, **Dex** +6, **Con** +6, **Int** +5, **Wis** +8, **Cha** +5

AC 46; **Fort** +34, **Ref** +34, **Will** +38

HP 380, regeneration 20 (deactivated by cold iron or lawful); **Resistances** physical 20 (except cold iron or lawful)

Buck ↷ DC 42

Frightful Presence (aura, emotion, fear, mental) 60 feet, DC 39

Wing Rebuff ↷ As roc.

Speed 20 feet, fly 80 feet

Melee ❖ beak +38 (reach 15 feet), **Damage** 4d12+18 piercing

Melee ❖ talon +38 (agile, reach 15 feet), **Damage** 4d8+18 slashing plus Improved Grab

Melee ❖ wing +38 (agile, reach 30 feet), **Damage** 4d8+18 bludgeoning plus Improved Push 10 feet

Occult Innate Spells DC 42, attack +34; **10th** *alter reality*; **9th** *phantasmal calamity*, *weird*; **8th** *phantasmal killer* (×3)

Flying Strike ❖❖ As roc.

Snack As roc.

Snatch As roc.

Unbloomed: If the Nights of Dread bloom (page 432) hasn't been defeated, the Nightmare Rook gains the elite adjustments (*Pathfinder Bestiary* 6) and becomes a 21st-level creature.

E. THE FRUITING ORCHARD MODERATE 18

A thirty-foot-high brick wall encircles a large clearing in the woods. Within, the riot of growth continues, but a tangle of mushrooms and fungus grow amid various tropical plants. Bulbs of brightly colored fruits the size of a human head hang from or grow on the trunks of many of the trees—and many of these bulbs twitch and pulse as if something within were attempting to escape.

Bloom Trophies: Dead mandragoras linked to the Shrieking Children bloom (page 430).

Creatures: This noxious orchard is where Nyrissa allows the "children of Thousandbreaths"—hundreds of thousands of tiny mandragoras—to dwell. The bulbous "fruits" on the mushrooms are in fact growing mandragoras nearing "birth."

While this garden is infested with mandragoras, just as the Shrieking Children bloom was infested, these mandragoras do not attack intruders as a swarm. Instead, they crawl together into an immense mound, leaving the tropical plants behind as they quickly spread their malleable bodies together to form a single 35-foot-tall mandragora.

IMMENSE MANDRAGORA CREATURE 20

UNIQUE CE GARGANTUAN PLANT

Variant mandragora (*Pathfinder Bestiary 2* 170)

Perception +33; blood scent, low-light vision

Languages Abyssal, Aklo, Common, Sylvan

Skills Acrobatics +35, Athletics +35, Stealth +38 (+46 in vegetation)

Str +10, **Dex** +5, **Con** +6, **Int** +0, **Wis** +7, **Cha** +6

Blood Scent As mandragora.

AC 43; **Fort** +34, **Ref** +31, **Will** +35

HP 400; **Weaknesses** fire 20; **Resistances** bludgeoning 20, electricity 20

Vulnerable to Supernatural Darkness As mandragora.

Speed 40 feet, burrow 10 feet, climb 40 feet

Melee ❖ jaws +38, **Damage** 4d12+18 piercing plus Improved Grab

Melee ❖ thorny vine +38 (agile, reach 30 feet), **Damage** 4d8+18 slashing plus immense mandragora venom

Blood Drain ❖ **Requirements** The immense mandragora has a creature grabbed; **Effect** The immense mandragora drains blood from the creature it has grabbed, dealing 12d6 damage. If the creature is a demon, fey, or sorcerer, the mandragora gains temporary Hit Points equal to the damage dealt. A creature that has its blood drained by a mandragora is drained 2 until it receives healing of any kind or amount.

Immense Mandragora Venom (poison) **Saving Throw** DC 42 Fortitude; **Maximum Duration** 6 rounds; **Stage 1** 4d6 damage and stupefied 1 (1 round); **Stage 2** 4d6 poison damage, confused, and stupefied 1 (1 round); **Stage 3** 6d6 poison damage, confused, and stupefied 1 (1 round)

Apocalyptic Shriek ❖ (auditory, evocation, mental, primal)
Frequency once per day; **Effect** The immense mandragora emits a devastating shriek. Each non-mandragora creature within 30 feet must attempt a DC 42 Will save.
Critical Success The creature is unaffected.
Success The creature is sickened 1 and takes 8d8 mental damage.
Failure The creature is sickened 2 and takes 16d8 mental damage.
Critical Failure The creature is sickened 2, slowed 1, and takes 150 mental damage. As long as the creature remains sickened, this slowed condition value can't be reduced below 1.

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Unbloomed: If the Shrieking Children bloom (page 430) hasn't been defeated, the PCs face two mandragora swarms here as well.

MANDRAGORA SWARMS (2) CREATURE 18

See page 430

Initiative Perception +30

F. THE SHUNNED FALLS MODERATE 18

A waterfall cascades between two immense stone hands carved from the peak of a stony cliff, tumbling into a large pool in this two-hundred-foot diameter forest glade. The pool is crystal clear, its shores thick with reeds and water-flowers of dazzling hue. Several large leaves the size of small boats float near the pool's shore, while immense glowing fireflies the size of human hearts bob and weave lazily in the air above.

The Shunned Falls is unique among the glades of Thousandbreaths in that it does not generate a bloom in the Stolen Lands, for this is the one place in Thousandbreaths that had already fallen from Nyrissa's direct control. It is here that evidence of her shame and guilt persists—a constant reminder to her that no matter how powerful she thinks she can become, the Eldest are more powerful still. As a result, Nyrissa hates this glade with a passion and rarely, if ever, visits here. Once the glade's current denizens (see Creatures, below) leave, it can be a safe place for beleaguered PCs to camp—Nyrissa and her minions do not intrude upon this region.

The large leaves that float on the water can serve as impromptu rafts for characters who wish to float downstream on the river. The large fireflies are harmless, but success on a DC 35 First World Lore, Nature, or Religion check notes that fireflies are sacred to the Lantern King.

Creatures: A mated pair of flying owlbears dwells here. While intelligent enough to understand Sylvan, the winged owlbears are little more than wild beasts as far as denizens of the First World are concerned and exist here simply because the glade is otherwise uncontrolled. They rise up to defend their territory as soon as they notice the PCs, fighting to the death.

WINGED OWLBEAR (2) CREATURE 18

N GARGANTUAN ANIMAL

Variant owlbear (*Pathfinder Bestiary* 259)

Perception +32; low-light vision, scent (imprecise) 30 feet

Languages Sylvan (can't speak any language)

Skills Acrobatics +31, Athletics +35, Intimidation +31

Str +9, **Dex** +5, **Con** +6, **Int** –2, **Wis** +5, **Cha** +4

AC 41; **Fort** +32, **Ref** +30, **Will** +30

HP 380

Speed 30 feet, fly 50 feet

Melee ❖ beak +35 (reach 10 feet), **Damage** 3d12+17 piercing plus 1d12 bleed

Melee ❖ talon +35 (agile, reach 20 feet), **Damage** 3d10+17 slashing plus Grab

Bloodcurdling Screech ❖ (auditory, emotion, fear, mental) As owlbear but DC 40 Will save.

WINGED OWLBEAR

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Gnaw ❖ As owlbear but DC 40 Will save.
Screeching Advance ❖❖ (auditory, emotion, fear, mental) As owlbear.

G. THE MIRE MODERATE 18

The trail ends at a great space in the forest that opens up into a foul-smelling marsh perhaps a mile or so across.

The mire's waters average 10 feet deep, but numerous crisscrossing troughs drop to depths of 30 feet throughout the swamp. Likewise, a maze of ridges that rises to within inches of the water surface (but average 1 foot below it) wind throughout the mire; a character can move through the mire along these ridges treating them as difficult terrain, but any character who makes more than one Move action in a round while walking along these ridges must succeed at a DC 30 Acrobatics check or slip off the edge of the ridge into one of the 30-foot-deep troughs.

Bloom Trophies: Twitching worms, linked to the Rise of the Mire Worms bloom (page 435).

Creatures: This bog is normally the den of he Wriggling Man, but Nyrissa asked him to join her in her home while she prepares to absorb the Stolen Lands. Yet the Wriggling Man has not left his swamp unguarded—four immense mire worms swim through the waters of the marsh, and they quickly surge forth to attack anyone who enters the glade.

MIRE WORMS (4) CREATURE 16

Elite azure worm (*Pathfinder Bestiary* 6, 57)
Initiative Perception +24

Unbloomed: If the Rise of the Mire Worms bloom (page 435) hasn't been defeated, the PCs face an additional two mire worms here.

H. THE KNURLY HOUSE MODERATE 18

The forest opens into a narrow clearing surrounded by bent, extremely broad trees. At the center of the clearing rises a strange sight: what appears to be two dozen different houses tangled together in a semi-organized mess, forming a conglomerate building where right angles seem unwelcome. A tangled yard filled with bristly vines and thorns surrounds the cottage.

This building is the Knurly House, all that remains of Nyrissa's first attempt to craft herself a house from the raw potential of the First World. She learned much from this initial attempt, and the House at the Edge of Time is a much more stable and well-organized affair.

The thorns that surround the Knurly House are 20 feet thick and 15 feet tall, save for a 10-foot-wide path leading to the house itself. A creature can move through the thorns but treats the overgrown area as both difficult terrain and hazardous terrain that deals 4d6 piercing damage each time the creature takes a Move action.

Bloom Trophies: Two-foot-long vines of tangled, knotted brambles, linked to the Knurly Briars bloom (page 434).

Creature: Nyrissa gave this house to one of her few true friends, a powerful hag cleric of the goddess Gyronna. This twisted annis hag has abandoned and forgotten her true name in favor of being known as the Knurly Witch. When the Knurly Witch first stumbled into Thousandbreaths 220 years ago, Nyrissa offered the annis a choice—die and feed her pet tarn linnorm, or live as Nyrissa's servant. The annis made the choice easily enough and does not regret it, for she has been treated well by Nyrissa. Over the centuries, Thousandbreaths has accepted her as one of its own, and she now functions as a native to the demiplane.

Although the Knurly Witch is as evil as they come, she doesn't immediately attack. She's been warned of the PCs by Nyrissa, and she's curious. She invites the PCs up to share tea with her as soon as she spots them. If the PCs agree to the invitation, the Knurly Witch adopts a strangely forthcoming and honest tactic as she serves them "tea." A successful DC 40 Perception check is enough for a PC to realize the mixture isn't actually tea. A PC that imbibes this foul mixture of crow's blood and powdered maggots must attempt a DC 38 Fortitude save to avoid becoming sickened 2 (sickened 4 on a critical failure). She simply starts asking the PCs what they're doing here in Thousandbreaths and tries to discern their powers, their goals, and their weaknesses through blunt questioning. If she thinks that it'll make the PCs more cooperative, she proposes a free trade of information: for each question of hers they answer, she'll answer one of theirs about Nyrissa. Of course, the Knurly Witch lies with each answer, trying to feed the PCs completely false information about the nymph queen in hopes that even if they believe one of her lies, their tactics will be compromised in a later confrontation. Eventually, either the Knurly Witch or the PCs are likely to grow tired of this, at which point the Knurly Witch can roll for initiative with a Deception check (she rolls with Perception if the PCs simply attack her on sight).

On the first round of combat, the Knurly Witch casts *air walk* and moves upward out of reach of foes on the ground. She casts *summon plant or fungus* the next round to summon a wemmuth (*Pathfinder Bestiary* 326), then uses her ranged spells against the PCs on the following rounds. If reduced to 250 Hit Points,

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she casts *regenerate*. Upon being reduced to 100 HP or less, she activates *word of recall* to retreat to her sanctuary in the House at the Edge of Time (area **K16**). There, she seeks out Nyrissa to report her failure to defend the Knurly House and prepares as mentioned in area **K16** to confront the PCs one last time.

THE KNURLY WITCH — CREATURE 20

UNIQUE | CE | LARGE | HAG | HUMANOID

Variant female annis hag (*Pathfinder Bestiary* 202)

Perception +38; darkvision

Languages Aklo, Common, Jotun, Sylvan

Skills Acrobatics +35, Athletics +34, Deception +37, Intimidate +34, Nature +36, Occultism +35, Religion +38

Str +6, **Dex** +7, **Con** +6, **Int** +2, **Wis** +10, **Cha** +6

Items religious symbol of Gyronna, *wand of slaying* (7th)

AC 45; **Fort** +32, **Ref** +35, **Will** +38; +1 status to all saves vs. magic, resolve

HP 324; **Resistances** physical 20 (except bludgeoning)

Resolve When the Knurly Witch rolls a success at a Will save, she gets a critical success instead.

Speed 40 feet

Melee ❖ claw +37 (agile, cold iron, magical, reach 10 feet), **Damage** 4d10+14 slashing plus Grab

Divine Prepared Spells DC 44, attack +38; **10th** *harm* (×7), *summon plant or fungus*; **9th** *heal*, *massacre*, *telepathic demand*; **8th** *dispel magic*, *flame strike*, *heal*; **7th** *divine decree*, *regenerate*, *divine wrath*; **6th** *blade barrier*, *feeblemind*, *paranoia*; **5th** *command*, *sending*, *tongues*; **4th** *air walk*, *discern lies*, *outcast's curse*; **3rd** *blindness*, *fear*, *zone of truth*; **2nd** *death knell*, *ghoulish cravings*, *see invisibility*; **1st** *command*, *ray of enfeeblement*, *sanctuary*; **Cantrips (10th)** *chill touch*, *daze*, *divine lance*, *read aura*, *shield*

Cleric Domain Spells 2 focus points, DC 44; **10th** *savor the sting*, *retributive pain*

Rituals DC 44; *blight*, *word of recall* (*Advanced Player's Guide* 245)

Divine Font *harm*

Bonds of Iron ❖❖ (attack, conjuration, occult) As annis hag, with an Escape DC of 42, AC 40, Hardness 20, and 80 HP.

Change Shape ❖ (concentrate, occult, polymorph, transmutation) As annis hag.

Rend ❖ claw

Word of Recall The Knurly Witch has used *word of recall* to bind herself to the House at the Edge of Time (area **K16**).

Treasure: A search of the Knurly House takes an hour. With success on a DC 35 Perception check, a PC discovers one of the treasures the Knurly Witch hid; a critical success discovers all four. These treasures consist of several journals written in Aklo that contain the formulas for two rituals (*blight* and *word of recall*), a set of *greater holy prayer beads*, a *+2 greater striking wounding dagger*, and a *ring of wizardry IV*.

Unbloomed: If the Knurly Briars bloom (page 434) hasn't been defeated, the PCs also face a particularly powerful athach gardener here—a monster who does his best to prevent any PC from approaching the Knurly Witch to fight her in melee.

ATHACH GARDENER — CREATURE 18

Elite Bloomborn athach (*Pathfinder Bestiary* 6, plus see page 434)

Initiative Perception +33

I. THE BALEFUL LANTERN — MODERATE 18

This small clearing is lit by ghastly yellow-green light that flickers like torchlight. The sources of the light are dozens of human heads that hang by their hair from spikes on the outer edge of a towering beehive-shaped structure in the center of the clearing—these heads function as horrific lanterns, with the light emerging from empty eye sockets and gaping mouths. Worse, the eyes and lips

THE KNURLY WITCH

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of several of these grisly lanterns seem to be twitching and writhing as if in pain.

This building is the home of one of Thousandbreaths' most hateful denizens: the Misbegotten Troll. The dozens of severed heads that decorate his strange home are the remains of his previous meals, unfortunate victims harvested over the past several hundred years. The glowing light is little more than an eerie side effect of the minor necromantic enhancement that makes the heads function as lanterns—the souls of these unfortunate victims have long since moved on.

Up until the month of destruction begins, the Misbegotten Troll served as the tether for this glade, but for the duration of this chapter that tether has been transferred to the building itself—the Baleful Lantern. If the PCs understand the nature of the glade tethers (by reaching at least 18 Research Points while investigating Thousandbreaths), success on a DC 38 check to Identify Magic while studying the structure reveals that the destruction of the Baleful Lantern will break this glade's tether.

The Baleful Lantern is AC 30, has Hardness 20, and has 400 HP (200 BT). If reduced to its Break Threshold, the structure creaks and groans; at this point a DC 43 Athletics check to Force Open its load-bearing metal bars can cause the entire thing to collapse. When the Baleful Lantern is destroyed, the collapse inflicts 20d6 bludgeoning damage (DC 35 basic Reflex save) to all creatures inside of it or within 30 feet of its exterior.

Bloom Trophies: Cages from the chain of lovelies, linked to the Misbegotten Troll bloom (page 435).

Creatures: The Misbegotten Troll left a pack of eight black smilodons to guard his home while he's out rampaging. If the PCs come to this area after defeating the troll on the Material Plane, these beasts are frenzied and eager for anything, and they attack on sight.

BLACK SMILODONS (8) CREATURE 14

Variant smilodons (Speartooth, page 104)
Initiative Perception +25

Unbloomed: If the Misbegotten Troll bloom (page 435) hasn't been defeated, the troll is instead encountered here as he feeds on a huge platter of a few dozen unfortunate grigs.

THE MISBEGOTTEN TROLL CREATURE 18

See page 436
Initiative Perception +31

J. THE HIGH FOLLY SEVERE 18

Thousands of mossy stone statues, each depicting a different creature, stand in this grassy clearing. At the clearing's center rises a low but strangely round hill, atop which rises a three-hundred-foot-high tower of white stone.

This glade contains the High Folly, a gatehouse that watches over the only path that leads to Nyrissa's home. The field of statues is an entire army of petrified First World monstrosities—a stone army that Nyrissa has been collecting with the aid of her medusa ally Phomandala (see area **M3**) for many years. When the War of the High Folly begins on day 26 of the month of destruction, this final bloom restores this army to flesh, and they are unleashed upon the PCs' capital city. Here on the First World, though, they are harmless. If the PCs have already defeated the War of the High Folly bloom, this clearing is empty of statues, and only the white stone tower—the High Folly itself—remains.

The High Folly is a hollow tower within which a single curving stairway rises to an observation platform under open roofs—the structure and purpose of the tower is similar to the leaning tower in area **C**, but a character who looks out from this tower's observation platform can see all of Thousandbreaths laid out below—almost exactly how the map at the end of *Zuddiger's Picnic* shows.

Bloom Trophies: Handfuls of sand taken from the scar left by the High Folly's passing, linked to the War of the High Folly bloom (page 437).

Creature: Ilthuliak terrorized the River Kingdoms of Pitax and Mivon as well as Numeria and Brevoy in her youth. She murdered and ate all would-be dragonslayers who hunted her, eventually attracting Nyrissa's attention. The nymph wooed Ilthuliak to relocate her lair to the High Folly with promises of power, treasure, and glory soon after the Stolen Lands drew her attention about two decades ago—and so far, Nyrissa has made good on those promises.

Ilthuliak remains vigilant at all times in the shadows atop the High Folly, a light sleeper and a keen observer as she looks out over the surrounding glade. If she notices the PCs approaching, she casts *time stop*, then uses that opportunity to cast *disappearance*, *spell turning*, and *true seeing*, while positioning herself in the air so she can use her breath weapon to maximum potential on the first round of combat when *time stop* ends. She opens combat with her breath weapon, following up with a few rounds flying overhead and casting spells like *reverse gravity*, *black tentacles*, and *weird*. Once her breath weapon has recharged, she swoops down to land amid the PCs to make good use of it, then loses herself in the glory of melee battle, periodically taking to the sky to cast a few more spells. Ilthuliak fights to the death.

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ILTHULIAK CREATURE 21

UNIQUE | CE | GARGANTUAN | ACID | AMPHIBIOUS | DRAGON

Variant female black dragon (*Pathfinder Bestiary* 105)

Perception +37; darkvision, scent (imprecise) 60 feet

Languages Aklo, Common, Draconic, Goblin, Jotun, Orcish, Sylvan

Skills Acrobatics +35, Arcana +36, Athletics +41, Deception +40, First World Lore +38, Intimidation +40, Stealth +35

Str +10, **Dex** +6, **Con** +7, **Int** +7, **Wis** +6, **Cha** +6

AC 47; **Fort** +38, **Ref** +35, **Will** +35; +1 status to all saves vs. magic, +4 status vs. mental

HP 450; **Immunities** acid, paralyzed, sleep

Frightful Presence (aura, emotion, fear, mental) 90 feet, DC 41

Tail Lash ↷ As young black dragon.

Speed 70 feet, fly 180 feet, swim 70 feet

Melee ❖ jaws +39 (acid, magical, reach 20 feet), **Damage** 4d12+18 piercing plus 2d6 acid and 2d6 persistent acid

Melee ❖ claw +39 (agile, magical, reach 15 feet), **Damage** 4d8+18 slashing

Melee ❖ tail +37 (magical, reach 25 feet), **Damage** 4d6+16 bludgeoning

Melee ❖ horns +37 (magical, reach 20 feet), **Damage** 3d6+16 piercing

Arcane Prepared Spells DC 44, attack +36; **10th** *time stop*; **9th** *disjunction*, *implosion*, *weird*; **8th** *disappearance*, *horrid wilting*, *mind blank* (already cast); **7th** *finger of death*, *reverse gravity*, *spell turning*; **6th** *dominate*, *true seeing*, *wall of force*; **5th** *black tentacles*, *dimension door*, *prying eye*; **4th** *clairvoyance*, *resilient sphere*, *suggestion*; **3rd** *blindness*, *slow*, *stinking cloud*; **2nd** *glitterdust*, *mirror image*, *telekinetic maneuver*; **1st** *command*, *ray of enfeeblement*, *true strike*; **Cantrips (10th)** *dancing lights*, *electric arc*, *prestidigitation*, *read aura*, *shield*

Arcane Innate Spells DC 44; **2nd** *darkness* (at will)

Breath Weapon ❖❖ (acid, arcane, evocation) Illthuliak breathes a spray of acid that deals 22d6 acid damage in a 100-foot line (DC 44 basic Reflex save). She can't use Breath Weapon again for 1d4 rounds.

Corrupt Water ❖ (arcane, concentrate, necromancy) As black dragon, but DC 41.

Treasure: Ilthuliak's treasure lies atop the High Folly in an impressive mound at the center of the observation platform. This hoard consists of 57,000 cp, 4,800 sp, 1,900 gp, 120 pp, a silver scepter set with strips of jet and ivory worth 250 gp, a darkwood jewelry box worth 100 gp that contains a tangle of costume jewelry and one necklace of precious gems worth 1,200 gp, a strange chunk of amber in which is trapped a mosquito that seems to have tiny hands at the tips of its feet (this strange bauble is worth 900 gp as long as the truth of it being a fanciful hoax remains obscured—a successful DC 35 Crafting check reveals the truth and its actual price of 5 gp), and assorted additional gemstones and minor trinkets worth an additional 1,000 gp. In addition, her lair contains several potent magic items: a +2 *greater striking returning thundering starknife*, *bracers of armor type II*, a *cassock of devotion*, a *cloak of the bat*, a *moderate thurible of revelation*, a *rod of negation*, and a *circlet of persuasion*.

ILTHULIAK

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PART 3:

HOUSE AT THE EDGE OF TIME

At Thousandbreaths' heart lies a House; yet this is no mortal edifice. Raised from the very fabric of reality in the First World at the height of Nyrissa's power before her paramour was exiled and her love was taken from her, this mansion is known as the House at the Edge of Time for its timeless quality. It has existed unchanged for Thousandbreaths' long existence, whereas the glades themselves shift and change to match Nyrissa's needs and interests. On one side, the House overlooks the panorama of Thousandbreaths, while the other side looks out over time and space—an endless gulf of stars and blackness shifting between mountains that rise and fall as if erosion took but the span of a single breath to reshape the land, giving the impression that the House stands at the literal edge of Time itself.

THE FINAL GLADE

The forest path opens at the shore of a vast lake, its waters still and dark. A stone bridge crosses the lake to an island at its center, where a walled gatehouse bars entry to the isle beyond. Beyond the gatehouse looms a sprawling manor, its steep roofs and twin towers stretching up into the sky. The tops of these towers seem to shift and shimmer, sometimes appearing to be simple stone edifices and other times being crowned with twisted, twitching trees or sinister-looking foliage. Likewise, the far side of the lake flickers and shimmers, one moment featuring images of vast mountains, the next featuring the endless expanse of the night sky, as if reality itself isn't sure what it wants to be.

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While in Thousandbreaths, the lake surrounding the House is effectively bottomless. Just as one can fly upward and never rise above the tree level, one can swim down into the lake without ever reaching the bottom. Fortunately the surface is never more than a few hundred feet away should a swimmer elect to return, despite the fact that the lake itself seems to be a mile across. The lake spills over the edge of its mesa in two places, to the left and right, to form the twin nameless rivers that frame Thousandbreaths and eventually meet again at the Whirling Lake, where the waters drain away to nowhere. If Thousandbreaths is uprooted, the waterfalls soon run dry as the lake drains to equilibrium—this results in a surface height change of only 20 feet. Additionally, the lake gains a bed at this time, although at 150 feet, it is still quite deep.

The House can be reached via a long stone bridge that connects its island to the mesa's edge. A flight of stairs rises up from the lakeshore to the bridge, which itself runs at a height of forty feet above the water. A gatehouse flanked by towers guards the far side's entrance to the House, while in the courtyard beyond, tall dark trees rise and rustle in the constant soft breeze. Dozens of windows stare out of the House itself, and stone fey hang from every gable. The outline of the House is as beautiful as it is dangerous, with knifelike crenellations, spear-topped towers, and eaves and shingles made of blades. Some parts of the House seem new and others old, but the structure as a whole is ancient and unchanging—even the sections of the House that appear to be ruins have always been that way (with exceptions noted in the text).

A PC who studies the two towers extending above the manor's roofs and succeeds at a DC 35 Nature check notes that the treelike vegetation that shifts in and out of reality atop the taller towers is a sort of visual projection from the First World, suggesting a concentration of primal magic there. A critical success on this check identifies the "tree" atop the shorter tower as a powerful sard (unless this creature has been relocated to the courtyard—see areas **K2** and **M2**).

APPROACHING THE HOUSE MODERATE 19

Regardless of whether the PCs use the bridge, swim, boat, or fly to the House, the approach is well protected. A tarn linnorm named Tarlaxian dwells in the lake, and it watches those who fly above its waters or cross the bridge. Tarlaxian won't pursue the PCs into the House itself, but he does encamp on the bridge to serve as a menacing guard against any attempt to flee the manor, ready to resume the attack if the PCs emerge. If the PCs attempt to use ranged attacks or spells against him from within the safety of the House, Tarlaxian simply retreats back into the waters of the lake.

TARLAXIAN CREATURE 21

Elite tarn linnorm (*Pathfinder Bestiary* 6, 226)
Initiative Perception +37

HOUSE FEATURES

The House at the Edge of Time exists in the past and the future, the maybe and the never. One room may be clean and bright while others are collapsing and decayed. Some have been damaged by the arrival of the PCs who slew Nyrissa yesterday and will do so tomorrow in this land of the impossible. Yet as strange as this warping of time may be, stranger still is the fact that such ripples and transformations remain constant, as if a storm of fractured time tore through the structure, only to be frozen forever in the middle of a chaos of a hundred different eras. This is how the House was when Nyrissa created it so long ago, and how it remains.

Doors, Walls, and Windows: The outer walls are covered in ironwood vines that have grown over the windows, effectively barring them. While these vines make climbing the walls easy (DC 10 Athletics check to Climb), they make breaking in through windows very difficult, as the vines are Hardness 22 and have 100 HP (BT 50). A character who succeeds at a DC 40 Athletics check to Force Open the vines allows someone to bend and rip a hole in the vines large enough to admit a Medium creature. Anyone climbing the House's outer walls quickly attracts the attention of the creatures that dwell atop the ivy tower (area **M2**), or the denizen of the courtyard (area **K2**).

All of the doors in the House are wooden. Each is carved with images of laughing, frowning, or frightened faces and open with a touch unless otherwise indicated. All stairwells in the House are steep and function as difficult terrain. Ceiling height in the House itself is 10 feet unless otherwise indicated in the text.

Helix Theorem: A PC who was present in the Spiral of Yog-Sothoth when the *Helix Theorem* was successfully performed (page 413) gains additional protection in the House at the Edge of Time, as the theorem bolsters their temporal presence in the flow of time. Any PC who is thus protected automatically realizes that the theorem protects them the first time they set foot in the House at the Edge of Time as they experience a disturbing sense of déjà vu and a "memory" that almost feels as if they're remembering something in the future that hasn't yet happened to them. At this point, the PCs know that they have gained a +4 status bonus on all saving throws made against teleportation effects or attempts to banish them to another plane while in the House at the Edge of Time. Additional protections manifest during a few specific encounters as well, as detailed below—when these occur, the PCs experience the same brief déjà vu and strange memories of the

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future, alerting them that their exposure to the *Helix Theorem* has protected them.

In addition, any PC who is protected by the *Helix Theorem* in this way knows that they can reflexively shed this protection in order to manipulate time itself once only. The PC gains the following free action as long as they are in the House at the Edge of Time and is protected by the *Helix Theorem*.

SHED TIME ◆

Trigger You fail or critically fail a saving throw, are hit by a Strike, or would increase your dying condition's value.

Requirements You are located in the House at the Edge of Time (including any of Nyrissa's fables) and are currently under the protection of the *Helix Theorem*.

You shed the timeline you currently occupy, then return to it once the triggering event passes. The exact effects depend on the nature of the triggering effect, as detailed below. You are no longer protected by the *Helix Theorem*; once this protection is lost, it cannot be regained.

Failed Saving Throw Shift the degree of success up from Failure to Success, or a Critical Failure up to a Failure, for the triggering saving throw.

Hit by a Strike. If the triggering Strike was a Critical Success, change it to a Success. If the triggering Strike was a Success, change it to a Failure.

Increase to Dying Condition. Instead of increasing your dying condition, you lose the dying condition.

Phantoms: The House is full of phantoms of yesterday and tomorrow. They can be glimpsed in mirrors, the scent of their perfume lingers at times in the air, and the meals they have yet to eat lie steaming on the table. The PCs are occasionally able to see or hear these phantoms, if only briefly. These phantoms can variously be of people and creatures they do not recognize, but now and then the phantoms draw from the PCs' own minds, pasts, and futures—these phantoms might remind the PCs of allies, old enemies thought dead, or even younger or older versions of themselves. In some cases, these temporal phantoms can actually interact with the present—the text of the encounter provides details as to where these effects can occur. In others, you should feel free to liven up an otherwise empty room with a strange glimpse of something half-seen or partially heard as you see fit.

Static Time: Features in the House can be altered (walls destroyed, doors bashed down, windows broken, furniture burnt, and denizens slain), but the contents of the House periodically "reset" as long as Nyrissa still lives. This reset occurs each time the PCs leave Thousandbreaths for any amount of time, unless they manage to uproot the demiplane. In this case, with the House's glade being the only part remaining, the reset occurs 24 hours after the PCs leave the House; if the PCs return before this time passes, the reset doesn't occur and the next time they leave, the 24-hour "countdown" begins anew.

When the House resets, broken doors reform, windows become unbroken, destroyed and disarmed traps rebuild themselves, and so on. Any resident of the House is restored to full Hit Points, and any ongoing affliction or magical effect that hampers them is subjected to a counteract attempt by the House, which has a 10th-level counteract check of +35. Residents that are killed remain dead, and when the PCs next return, any remains left behind have decayed away to skeletons as if years had passed. Residents that have been relocated to another plane entirely are similarly not restored by the House's reset. Any items (such as treasure) the PCs brought with them out of the House when it resets do not vanish, but upon returning to the rooms where they found these items, the PCs discover phantasmal images of the removed items lingering in the places where they were originally found.

Warped Dimensions: Time is not the only thing that's warped in the House—the dimensions themselves are as well. In most cases, these manifest as strange curiosities, such as the elevation change in the courtyard not being reflected in the surrounding House itself, or the inverted storeroom at area **K8**, or simply the fact that while some of the rooms have different ceiling heights or floor depths when explored, the exterior of the House suggests each floor has a constant level.

Of greater concern, though, is how teleportation effects function in the House. When a visitor to the House attempts any teleportation action, allow them a DC 40 Perception (master) check (or DC 35 Perception for any PC under the influence of the *Helix Theorem*) to notice something strange going on with the magic as they begin the action—the effect simply seems "off." The PC can halt the action at this point without losing the resource to teleport. If the PC doesn't notice the strange sensation or proceeds to take the action anyway, they activate the House's teleport trap. This trap does not affect any natives to Thousandbreaths or the House itself (including those like the Knurly Witch who have acclimated to the demiplane over time).

TELEPORT TRAP HAZARD 19

MAGICAL TRAP

Stealth DC 40 (master)

Description The House at the Edge of Time folds time and space back on the target, who teleports painfully into their own body an instant before they travel.

Disable This trap cannot be disabled as long as Nyrissa lives, but if she is slain or forgiven (see area **M7**), the teleport trap vanishes.

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Warp Teleportation ↷ **Trigger** A non-native of Thousandbreaths attempts to take a teleportation action that either begins or ends in any area within the House at the Edge of Time; **Effect** The House redirects the magic to cause the creature that attempted the Teleportation action to instead teleport into themselves a split second before they attempted the action in the first place. The creature must attempt a DC 41 Will save. A PC under the protection of the Helix Theorem gains their +4 status bonus to this saving throw, and treats all Critical Failure results as Failure results instead.

Critical Success The action functions normally.

Success The action fails but doesn't harm anyone.

Failure The action fails, and the creature that attempted it (but not any other creature targeted by the action) teleports into themselves, suffering a sudden and agonizing pain, taking 4d10+40 bludgeoning damage, 4d10 mental damage, and becoming stunned 1.

Critical Failure As failure, but affecting all creatures that would have been affected by the attempted action, and the creature that attempted the action instead takes 80 bludgeoning damage, 40 mental damage, and is stunned 4.

NYRISSA'S REVENGE LOW 19

Nyrissa doesn't take an active part in the defense of her House until the PCs confront her in area **M7**. Until then, she focuses on preparing to absorb the Stolen Lands into the *Apology*.

If the PCs have already defeated this plan, either by enduring the month of destruction or by uprooting Thousandbreaths, Nyrissa's plans shift to vengeance. The PCs have foiled her plans, but if she can defeat them and recover *Briar*, she hopes that she might be able to sidestep the final kingdom needed to fill the *Apology*. As long as the PCs remain in the House, she bides her time in area **M7**, but if the PCs retreat back to the Material Plane, Nyrissa sends agents to attack them. She draws these agents from the First World via *primal call*, calling upon four of her defaced nymphs to serve as secondary casters.

Nyrissa performs this ritual in area **M7**, which alters the way the ritual functions. Here, the chance to perform *primal call* is a DC 35 check. The ritual, if successful, manifests a creature from Thousandbreaths itself. Nyrissa must still expend ingredients when she performs the ritual. If Thousandbreaths has been uprooted, this energy is drawn instead from the House at the Edge of Time—all that remains in the demiplane. In this case, Nyrissa and the defaced nymphs suffer a –4 circumstance penalty to their skill checks to perform the ritual.

Nyrissa always performs this *primal call* ritual at 10th level. She uses it to call an elite primal bandersnatch (page 610), elite sard (*Pathfinder Bestiary 2* 6, 231), or elite terotricus (*Pathfinder Bestiary* 6, 311), varying her choice each time so that the PCs won't quite know what to expect. Each attempt at the ritual costs her 200 gp in resources, drawn from the supplies in area **M7**; she has enough supplies to attempt the ritual 10 times. She doesn't need to offer additional payment to the creature, and she sends it on its way into the Material Plane to track down and attack the PCs. The creature manifests at the Castle of Knives (encounter site **TV1**) in Thousand Voices. How it tracks down and attacks the PCs is left to you to determine.

Nyrissa continues performing *primal call* rituals in this way daily. Once she depletes her resources for casting the ritual, or once she rolls a critical failure on her check, she can no longer pursue this avenue of vengeance. Unwilling to leave her demiplane or to risk the House's actual guardians, Nyrissa now turns her attention to hunkering down and waiting out the PCs. It'll take her years to refocus her attentions on a new kingdom on a different world to attempt to gain her final apology—if it comes to this, the PCs can simply leave her alone and this chapter concludes. Yet the campaign continues, for the Lantern King himself grows impatient if this stalemate continues for too long—see Chapter 11 for details.

RAISED ALARMS

The occupants of the House at the Edge of Time are aware of the PCs and await their arrival, so the structure's defenders are already on high alert. If the alarm is raised, all of the House's occupants become hypervigilant, gaining a +2 circumstance bonus on initiative checks for the next 24 hours.

THE POWER OF FORGIVENESS

Some of the creatures in the House at the Edge of Time—the ghostly guards and defaced naiad queens, but most notably Nyrissa herself—still harbor vestiges of goodness in their minds and souls that can be appealed to by PCs who seek to forgive them for their actions. A PC can learn about the Forgive Foe action accidentally if they seek to appeal to a creature in the House at the Edge of Time in this way on their own, or they can learn about it by closely observing how certain creatures act when they attack certain foes.

These foes have a Shame entry in their stat block. When such a foe attacks specific targets delineated in their Shame entry, they suffer a –2 status penalty on attack rolls and to all save DCs to resist their spells or attacks. Whenever such a creature takes an action that triggers this penalty, all creatures within 30 feet can attempt a Perception check against the acting creature's

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Deception DC. On a success, the creature attempting the check realizes the creature taking the action is suffering from guilt and shame at their own action; this reveals that a Forgive Foe action might help the acting creature recover from its plight.

FORGIVE FOE ◆◆

AUDITORY | CONCENTRATE | LINGUISTIC | MENTAL

You make an attempt to force a foe to confront its guilt and face its shame for its actions. When you do so, attempt either a Diplomacy check or another check as indicated in the creature's Shame entry; the DC is the creature's Will DC.

Critical Success Your words strike home and allow the creature to escape its servitude to the House at the Edge of Time. The specific effects of this are listed in the creature's Shame entry.

Success Your words give the foe pause. It suffers a –2 status penalty on all attacks, effect DCs, and its Will DC against additional Forgive Foe attempts until the end of your next turn.

Critical Failure Your attempt fails so dramatically that you instead fuel the creature's wrath and effectively blind it to its sense of shame and guilt. For the next 24 hours, it no longer suffers the effects of shame when it attacks you and you can no longer attempt to Forgive that Foe.

GHOSTLY GUARD

K1. GATEHOUSE MODERATE 19

A stone gatehouse bars entry into the sprawling manor's courtyard beyond with a lowered portcullis. In the walls above, arrow slits leer down while a forty-foot-high wall extends from the gatehouse in both directions to connect to two more towers.

The iron portcullis (Hardness 18, HP 72 [BT 36]) can be Forced Open with a DC 38 Athletics check. Alternately, it can be raised or lowered from the upper floor of the gatehouse (area **K1b**). Although there are several guards posted here and along the wall, the denizen of the courtyard (area **K2**) comes to defend the area if it notices anyone breaking into area **K1a**.

Creatures: Undead are rare in the First World, for it is a realm infused with life, but here in the House at the Edge of Time that overabundance of life is muted. Nyrissa's house guards are thankful for this because they are ghosts. Once members of an ancient elven kingdom on a distant world, these elves were the first victims of Nyrissa's quest to claim a thousand kingdoms. She has never been able to replicate the transformation of a nation's greatest warriors into ghostly guards like this since that first conquest, but since these ghosts rejuvenate as long as Nyrissa lives, she's never had need for reinforcements.

As ghosts, these guards are eternally vigilant; they need not take breaks to eat, sleep, or entertain themselves. At any one time, four stand guard in area **K1b**, one atop each of the towers (areas **K1c** and **K1d**), and one atop each of the walls to either side of the gatehouse, amounting to eight ghostly guards in all.

When these ghosts spot intruders, they use their frightful moan more as an alarm than an attack, then they proceed to use Ectoplasmic Maneuver to attempt to disarm the intruders. After a few rounds, four of the ghosts swoop down to engage the PCs in melee while the other four fly up to make ranged attacks. The ghostly guards fight until destroyed.

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HOUSE AT THE EDGE OF TIME: LEVEL ONE
ONE SQUARE = 5 FEET

GHOSTLY GUARDS (8) CREATURE 15

RARE | CE | MEDIUM | GHOST | INCORPOREAL | SPIRIT | UNDEAD

Elf ghost (*Pathfinder Bestiary* 116)

Perception +29; darkvision

Languages Elven, Sylvan

Skills Acrobatics +29, Intimidate +29, Nature +27, Stealth +31

Str –5, **Dex** +4, **Con** +0, **Int** +4, **Wis** +6, **Cha** +6

Shame A ghostly guard suffers from shame (page 459) when it attacks a target that appears to be an elf or a worshipper of Calistria. Forgive Foe can be attempted against a ghostly guard with a DC 39 Diplomacy check or Society check. If a ghostly guard is affected by a critical success from Forgive Foe, it sighs in relief as it fades away, its soul released into the afterlife.

Site Bound

AC 35; **Fort** +23, **Ref** +27, **Will** +29

HP 210, negative healing, rejuvenation; **Immunities** death effects, disease, paralyzed, poison, precision, unconscious; **Resistances** all damage 15 (except force, *ghost touch*, or positive; double resistance vs. non-magical)

Rejuvenation (divine, necromancy) Slaying or forgiving Nyrissa allows the ghostly guards to move on to their long-delayed afterlives, as does achieving a critical success with Forgive Foe.

Speed fly 30 feet

Melee ❖ ghostly rapier +27 (deadly d8, finesse), **Damage** 3d6+12 negative plus 2d6 bleed

Ectoplasmic Maneuver ❖ (attack) The ghostly guard lashes out with a whipping strand of solid ectoplasm against a target within 15 feet, in an attempt to Disarm, Shove, or Trip the foe. It uses its ghostly rapier Strike rather than an Athletics check to determine the results of this attempt.

Frightful Moan ❖❖ (auditory, divine, emotion, enchantment, fear, mental) As ghost, but Will DC 36.

Sneak Attack A ghostly guard deals 3d6 extra precision damage to flat-footed creatures.

K2. THE GREAT COURTYARD VARIES 19

This large courtyard is a two-tiered region covered with thick grass. Paths wind to and from various doors, and a single, wide flight of stairs allows easy access to the courtyard's second tier, where several towering oak trees loom over the main body of the House.

A subtle but strange warping of reality exists within the boundaries of this courtyard—while the main body of the House is all on the same level as the upper tier, the entrance to area **K14** lies on the same level as the lower tier despite the fact that one can walk from area **K14** to **K2** via the House without seeming to change elevation. The branches of the tallest tree in the courtyard (the one just south of area **K12**) are one of

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the four entrances to the Fable—they lead to area **M7b** (see that area for how one can enter the Fable via this tree's branches).

Creature: The guardian of the Great Courtyard is a huge and dangerous creature—but its nature depends on whether the PCs have already encountered and slain the lesser jabberwock at the end of Part 1. If the events of Day 28 have yet to occur, then the lesser jabberwock still lurks here amid the trees of the courtyard's upper tier. If, on the other hand, the lesser jabberwock has already been slain, Nyrissa has replaced it with the less dangerous but equally enormous sard from area **M2**. In either case, the monstrous guardian won't pursue foes into the House itself, but it will chase intruders for several minutes if they attempt to flee the region.

An encounter with the lesser jabberwock is a Moderate 19 encounter, while one with an elite sard is a Low 19 encounter.

LESSER JABBERWOCK CREATURE 21

See page 440

Initiative Perception +36

ELITE SARD CREATURE 20

Pathfinder Bestiary 2 6, 231

Initiative Perception +37

K3. STABLES

Six narrow stalls line the far wall of this stable.

Soon after the PCs enter, the unsettling sight of a dead horse hanging its head miserably over a stable door confronts them. Despite appearances, this is no undead horse. Rather, these six stalls each maintain a magical steed that can be "keyed" to a rider by simply opening the door to a stall and beckoning the undead-looking horse out. Each of these mounts function as a *phantom steed* spell heightened to 6th level. The duration of the spell begins when a steed is removed from the stall, and a replacement steed appears here 4 hours after the previous one disappears.

K4. LOWER HALL MODERATE 19

The polished marble floor of this otherwise empty chamber depicts a carving of the sun being devoured by a great dragon. The walls are painted to resemble a twilit forest with strange, dark shapes hiding amid the trees.

Creatures: The carving on the floor is harmless, but the dark shapes that seem to lurk amid the trees on the walls are not. These are powerful ankou assassins, guardians placed here by Nyrissa, eager to attack intruders and feel hot blood run over their dark talons. What Nyrissa doesn't realize is that these ankous are in fact also spies for the Lantern King; if she manages to capture the Stolen Lands or reclaim *Briar*, the ankous abandon this area and return to their patron's side to report. Otherwise, they'll slip out of hiding among the shadows on the walls to attack as soon as anyone notices that they're not merely decorations, or as soon as someone attempts to leave the room.

If an ankou assassin is reduced to fewer than 50 HP, it flees the House and does not return.

ANKOU ASSASSINS (4) CREATURE 17

RARE LE LARGE FEY

Variant ankou (*Pathfinder Bestiary 2* 19)

Perception +30; lifesense 120 feet, low-light vision

Languages Aklo, Common, Sylvan (can't speak any language); telepathy 100 feet

Skills Acrobatics +34, Deception +31, Intimidation +34, Nature +28, Stealth +34

Str +8, **Dex** +9, **Con** +5, **Int** +3, **Wis** +3, **Cha** +6

AC 40; **Fort** +28, **Ref** +32, **Will** +29

HP 333; **Weaknesses** cold iron 15

Speed fly 75 feet

Melee ❖ claw +33 (agile, cold iron), **Damage** 3d8+16 slashing

Melee ❖ wing +33 (cold iron, reach 10 feet), **Damage** 2d8+16 piercing plus 2d6 persistent bleed

Primal Innate Spells DC 38, attack +30; **9th** *massacre*; **8th** *darkness* (at will), *dimensional anchor*, *discern location*; **7th** *prismatic spray*, *silence*, *teleport*; **6th** *ray of enfeeblement*, *true seeing*

Shadow Doubles ❖ to ❖❖❖ As ankou but with 110 Hit Points, +27 for their Strikes, and a DC 43 Perception check to Seek and identify them as a shadow double.

Sneak Attack An ankou assassin's Strikes deal an additional 3d6 precision damage to flat-footed creatures.

K5. DINING ROOM

This dusty dining room seems to have been unused for decades. A huge wooden table fills the chamber, eight fine chairs drawn up to its sides. What appears to be a faintly glowing phantom meal is laid out on the table, and periodically bits of food or drink rise up and vanish as if being consumed by invisible diners. A statue of a beautiful woman stands in one corner of the room.

This feasting hall has not been used in centuries; the phantasmal food is an echo of the ancient past—the last time Nyrissa hosted a dinner party. The diners are not present, but the dinner moves and floats as if they are. Any PC who enters this room feels an urge to sit at the table to join the feast, but they can resist with ease.

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Those who do sit at the table and spend even a single action sampling the phantom food must attempt a DC 39 Fortitude save. On a success, the PC gains 30 temporary Hit Points and can immediately attempt a new saving throw against any ongoing disease or poison effect they are suffering against that affliction's save; on a success, the affliction instantly ends. If the PC fails the Fortitude save from eating the phantasmal food, they instead become drained 2 (or drained 4 on a critical failure) as the phantom food saps their life force. Once a PC has been affected by the food, they become immune to further effects from it. This phantasmal echo can be countered with *dispel magic* (9th-level effect, counteract DC 38).

Treasure: The statue is a faithful rendition of the nymph Nyrissa but is otherwise unremarkable save for the magical cloak draped over its shoulders; it appears to be a *cloak of the bat* but is in fact a cursed type IV *poisonous cloak* (*Pathfinder Gamemastery Guide* 91).

K6. DANCING BEAR

This room is dominated by a domed cage, its verdigris-encrusted surface caked with muck. A taxidermy black bear stands lifelessly within.

The rubble-filled hall that leads to area **K17** is treated as difficult terrain.

Hazard: Moments after the PCs enter the chamber, the bear in the cage lumbers onto its hind legs and begins a slow but strangely graceful dance, made all the more grotesque by the fact that the bear is obviously dead and stuffed. One of Nyrissa's many amusements, the bear is not undead but is a taxidermy animal rigged to serve as a dangerous trap against intruders. The bear itself is quite simple to destroy—indeed, this is part of the threat, for if it is destroyed, it explodes.

EXPLOSION BEAR — HAZARD 20

UNIQUE | FIRE | MAGICAL | TRAP

Stealth 48 (legendary)

Description An invisible rune causes the animated bear to explode if it is destroyed or if it finishes its dance while anyone is in the room.

Disable Thievery DC 48 (legendary) to erase the rune without triggering the explosion (the DC is increased to 51 while the bear is moving), *dispel magic* (10th level, counteract DC 39) to counteract the rune, or Nyrissa says the words "Good bear" to the trap before it finishes its dance.

AC 20; **Fort** +8, **Ref** +14

HP 40 [BT 20]

Fireball ↷ (arcane, evocation, fire) **Trigger** The animated bear is reduced below its BT, or it finishes its three-round dance while there are still people in the room; **Effect** The rune detonates into a blast of fire centered on the bear. All creatures within a 20-foot radius of the center of area **K6** take 16d10 fire damage (DC 42 basic Reflex save).

K7. OBSERVATORY

An arched opening looks out from the far side of this room, providing the large brass telescope in the middle of the room an excellent field of view.

The spyglass was used by Nyrissa to look at the stars and moon and planetary bodies beyond Thousandbreaths, but she hasn't used the telescope in some time. The window itself is a one-way opening—it simply doesn't exist on the outside. A character who climbs out the window can notice this strange quality with a DC 30 Perception check, and as long as they retreat back into area **K7** before fully exiting the House they can do so safely; otherwise, they'll need to circle the manor to re-enter from the courtyard.

Treasure: The telescope is quite heavy (80 pounds—8 Bulk) but quite valuable—it's worth 3,500 gp.

K8. STOREROOM

What this oddly-shaped storeroom may have once held is impossible to tell, for its shelves today are empty.

While the room appears to be empty, success at a DC 30 Perception check or a DC 20 Architecture Lore check reveals that the shelves in the room seem to have been installed upside down.

In fact, the room itself is upside down, and anything that enters the room, be it a thrown coin or a PC or anything else, suddenly falls upward to the ceiling. This is hardly even a minor hazard for high-level PCs (it's just a DC 15 Reflex save to Grab the Edge of the doorframe to avoid a fall for 5 points of damage), but it should serve as a dramatic reminder that not everything in the House is as it appears.

K9. THE SWILL FEAST

This was obviously some sort of dining room. A great oak table is pushed up against one wall while several rickety chairs line the opposite wall. The rotting remnants of a vast feast lie upon the table—silver tureens spill fungal rot, a tarnished silver salver lies ruptured on its side, and old bones cover a number of plates. The entire place reeks of garbage and decay.

Treasure: This room is unremarkable, but if the silver service is cleaned, it's worth 1,300 gp.

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K10. POISONED WELL

A covered well is this chamber's only feature.

This well drops 100 feet into waters that, while cool and crystal clear, are tainted with disease—anyone who drinks from the well is exposed to a 20th-level strain of blinding sickness (*Pathfinder Gamemastery Guide* 119, but DC 40 Fortitude save).

K11. TELEPORTER ENTRANCE

This small chamber seems to have been decorated with an eye toward meditation. The themes herein are all of the natural world; a sumptuous stained glass window dominates the far wall, while six green candlesticks carved to look like writhing trees light the room. A large round dais of stone sits in one corner of the room.

Success at a DC 40 check made to Identify Magic while studying the stone dais reveals that it once functioned as a portal to come and go from the First World, but that functionality has been lost. Nonetheless, the dais does have a useful feature, for any attempt to teleport to this dais automatically bypasses the teleport trap that wards the House (page 458). Nyrissa isn't aware of this strange side effect yet, but each time the PCs use this to teleport to area **K11**, roll a DC 50 Perception check for Nyrissa to determine if she notices the strange fluctuation in the House's ambient magic. If she does, she casts *sending* to order one of her minions to investigate—the Wriggling Man is the most likely choice. Once she's made aware of what caused the fluctuation, Nyrissa manipulates the House's magic; an hour later, this dais loses all magical properties, potentially setting up a shock to the PCs the next time they try to teleport to this room.

Treasure: The six intricately carved jade candlesticks are worth 5,000 gp each.

K12. STAIRWELL

These stairs lead up to area **L5**.

K13. SALON OF CONFUSING SOUNDS LOW 19

This salon is decorated with vivid frescoes depicting primeval forests filled with floral blooms and beautiful women. Two plush sofas sit against the walls, while three low tables in the middle of the room hold beautiful floral arrangements. The sounds of some sort of celebration may be heard in this room as if from a great distance.

Hazard: The faint sounds of celebration are phantoms and echoes from the past; the longer one remains in this room, the more the listener loses track of whether it's the sounds themselves that are distant or if it's themselves who are distant, being pushed away out of time and space by eldritch forces.

A PC who is under the protection of the *Helix Theorem* applies their +4 status bonus to all rolls and checks made against this hazard.

ELDRITCH ECHOES HAZARD 20

COMPLEX MAGICAL TRAP

Stealth DC +38 (master) to realize that the strange faint sounds could be dangerous.

Description Those who listen to the sounds for too long become convinced that these forces can be defeated by lashing out at them, even though the forces themselves are not apparent.

Disable DC 42 Performance (master) to counter the eerie sounds by exceeding their influence with a virtuoso act, or DC 48 Intimidation (master) to startle the echoes into silence with a display of anger and rage.

Distort Senses ↻ (auditory, emotion, enchantment, mental, primal) **Trigger** At least two creatures who aren't native to Thousandbreaths end their turn in area **K13**. **Effect** Those in the room begin "hearing" the sounds in the room telepathically and start to have difficulty telling the difference between these sounds and those of their allies; the trap then rolls initiative.

Routine (1 action; emotion, enchantment, mental, primal) The trap starts scrambling senses and forcing creatures to perceive threats to their very place in time and space where no such threats actually exist. Every creature in area **K13** must attempt a DC 42 Will saving throw.

Critical Success The creature is unaffected.

Success The creature is stupefied 1 for 1 round.

Failure As success, but the creature is also confused as long as it remains stupefied.

Critical Failure The creature is stupefied 2 and confused. The confused condition persists until the creature recovers normally, but the stupefaction effect is permanent until removed.

Treasure: The decor in this room is elegant and impressive, but the expensive furniture decays to rot and mold if brought out of the room. Nonetheless, a 10-minute Search of the room and success at a DC 35 Perception check are enough to discover a slender platinum flute under one of the sofa cushions. This flute is a *greater maestro's instrument*.

K14. HALL OF WEEPING DEMONS

This room is lined with strange, decaying plants. An empty pool sits in its center, and the walls are decorated with hundreds of small statues of sobbing demons.

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Treasure: Success on a DC 40 Perception check notes that one of the hundreds of sobbing demons in fact appears to be laughing. Removing this demon from the shelf causes the plants in the room to bloom into life and the empty pool to fill with water as the weeping demon statues cry streams of real tears that run down to collect in the center of the room. The pool takes 1 minute to fill completely, after which success on a DC 36 check to Identify Magic reveals its properties: The water casts *restoration* heightened to 6th level on anyone who steps into the pool, and also restores 150 HP. Each use causes the pool to shrink in size; there is enough water in the pool for three such uses.

The room "recharges" when the House resets, as long as Thousandbreaths hasn't been uprooted—in this case, the room does not recharge once the pool's three uses have been consumed.

K15. SERVANTS' WING — SEVERE 19

This wing of the House serves as workrooms for the servants. If the PCs enter this wing, they'll quickly attract the anger of the wing's guardians.

Area **K15a** was used for quick naps and relaxation. Area **K15b**, once used to arrange meals in pleasing presentations, is filled with rubble (this room is difficult terrain). Area **K15c** was used to prepare flower garlands, while area **K15d** was a parlor for discussing the day's duties. Area **K15e** was the wing's kitchen, while area **K15f** was used to store supplies. The servants themselves dined in area **K15g**, stored food and drink in area **K15h**, and kept preserved herbs and spices in area **K15i**—this last room also contains a trap door that opens at a touch (like the other doors in the complex) to reveal a ladder leading down to area **K16**.

Creatures: No living servants remain here, but the wing is far from unoccupied. A group of a dozen ghostly guards can be found here, pantomiming various duties in the rooms. Areas **K15c–K15e** and **K15h** are each occupied by two ghosts. A group of three ghosts mime eating a meal in area **K15g**, while the final ghost apes the cataloging of herbs and spices in **K15i**.

As soon as any of these ghosts notice the PCs, they use their Frightful Moans to raise the alarm. This causes all the other ghosts in this wing to join the fight as soon as possible. If the Knurly Witch has retreated to area **K16**, she hears these howls and clambers up the ladder to join the fight as well. She makes good use of *harm* to keep the ghosts healed.

GHOSTLY GUARDS (12) — CREATURE 15

See page 461

Initiative Perception +29

K16. CELLAR — LOW 19

This earthen-floored cellar contains all manner of mundane supplies such as firewood, food, tools, lumber, and a surprising number of gourds drying on twine hanging from the rafters.

The cellar is split into three rooms, with the farthest from the ladder having been converted into a bedroom.

Creature: This chamber is the home-away-from-home for the Knurly Witch when she visits the House—she chose this room out of all those offered her by Nyrissa because she likes the ambiance. If the Knurly Witch fled a previous encounter with the PCs, she can be found here nursing her wounds and her pride. If confronted here, she fights to the death.

THE KNURLY WITCH — CREATURE 20

See page 453

Initiative Perception +38

K17. THRONE ROOM — MODERATE 19

Turquoise tiles adorn the walls of this chamber, with a false gallery hanging some ten feet above the tiled floor. An ornate wooden bridge crosses the chamber thirty feet above the floor, connecting doors on the building's second floor—the vaulted ceiling rises another ten feet above that. Incredible paintings depicting animals in sylvan scenes cover this ceiling. The first shows a wolf in a forest with a severed hand clenched in its jaws. The second depicts a great viper approaching a crib, while the third shows a huge bear stalking a mother and child. An archway decorated with a dragon eating a mounted knight at one end of the room opens to a great iron spiral staircase leading upward, while at the other end of the hall sits a regal throne made of marble shot through with green veins. Two statues of beautiful women wielding upraised swords stand to either side of the throne, while a long purple carpet runs the length of the room. Numerous chairs and benches line the walls.

Nyrissa has not used this room in ages—her followers know what to do and there is little need for the nymph to address them. The stairs lead up to area **L1**, and the wooden bridge is area **L7**. The walls can be Climbed with a DC 30 Athletics check.

The throne is one of the four entrances to the Fable; it leads to area **M7c** (see that area for how one can enter the Fable via the throne).

Creature: With Nyrissa all but abandoning this room, its care has been entrusted to one of her most dangerous allies: her personal advisor, the Wriggling Man.

The Wriggling Man does not recall his life before his death and subsequent transformation into a worm that

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walks, save that he came to the First World on a long-forgotten mission. That he failed in this mission seems obvious, for it was after his failure and death that his mind and spirit infested the worms that fed upon his rotting remains and he was reborn as a worm that walks.

The Wriggling Man soon found work as Nyrissa's advisor in all things arcane; while Nyrissa herself is a talented spellcaster, her gifts are inborn, not the result of study, and she appreciates help with her more complex plans. His aid has been instrumental in helping Nyrissa manipulate nascent kingdoms on hundreds of other worlds to prepare them for absorption into the *Apology*; currently, his only task is to await the PCs, ambush them, and kill them.

Warned by Nyrissa of the PCs' approach as soon as they enter the House at the Edge of Time, the Wriggling Man has settled upon a cunning plan to both amuse himself and potentially disrupt the PCs' plans. He casts *illusory scene* on the northern end of the room to make it appear that the two statues of Nyrissa stand to either side of the throne rather than behind it, and includes a wall just behind the throne itself to completely obscure the northernmost five feet of the room. He then hides behind the throne north of the illusion to await the PCs' arrival.

As soon as he notices the PCs entering the chamber, he rolls for initiative using Stealth. On his turn, he casts *time stop*, then casts *veil* to appear as an 8-foot-tall, Medium-sized angel with golden skin on the first of his three rounds. On the second round he casts *ventriloquism*, and on the third *project image* to make himself appear (as an angel) 30 feet south of the throne in the middle of the chamber.

When his *time stop* ends, the Wriggling Man, in his disguise, seems to appear out of nowhere in the middle of the room. He continues to sustain *project image* each round while remaining hidden behind the throne, and asks the PCs to stay their hands, hoping to trick them into thinking he's actually an angelic guardian.

If the PCs hold off on attacking, the Wriggling Man imperiously informs the PCs that they must leave this House at once, lest they further intrude upon the works of one under the protection of Heaven itself. This is, of course, a lie—the Wriggling Man doesn't expect the PCs to fall for it for long (if at all), but the tactic does amuse him. If the tactic works, he strings the PCs along with stories of how Heaven's armies have come to the House at the Edge of Time to contain its dangers, and that from this point forward, no further action on the PCs' behalf is needed to keep their kingdom safe. If the ruse works and the PCs leave, the Wriggling Man is somewhat surprised, but as soon as the PCs exit the room, he drops the *project image*, casts *invisibility*, and then follows them for a minute to make sure they leave. If they don't, he'll keep on them until they get into a fight or his *invisibility* is about to end, at which point he'll join the battle to make things even more dangerous for the PCs.

If the PCs see through the ruse, though, the Wriggling Man is more than willing to fight. He continues to sustain his *project image* as long as it makes sense to do so, casting offensive spells through the illusion as needed to fight the PCs. If his illusions are penetrated, he'll work to avoid melee as best as he can, but if his magic incapacitates a character, he can't resist approaching the poor PC to engulf them in his Squirming Embrace. He relies on his *contingency* spell to rescue him if he gets into trouble; if he does manage to escape to area **M6** he'll remain away only as long as it takes for him to recover his health, at which point he *dimension doors* back into this room to track the PCs down and attack again—but this time he fights to the death.

THE WRIGGLING MAN CREATURE 21

UNIQUE | CE | MEDIUM | ABERRATION | SWARM

Variant male worm that walks wizard (*Pathfinder Bestiary 2* 296)

Perception +35, darkvision, tremorsense (imprecise) 30 feet

Languages Abyssal, Aklo, Common, Draconic, Sylvan, Terran, Undercommon

Skills Acrobatics +39, Arcana +41, Deception +39, Nature +37, Society +41, Stealth +39

Str +5, **Dex** +9, **Con** +5, **Int** +10, **Wis** +6, **Cha** +8

Items *bag of holding type IV* (containing small library of spellbooks containing all of his prepared spells, plus all additional common spells of 1st–6th level and any additional spells you wish to introduce into the campaign), *+2 greater fire resistant greater resilient leather armor*, *major staff of transmutation*

AC 47, all-around vision; **Fort** +34, **Ref** +39, **Will** +35; +4 status vs. mental

HP 325, fast healing 20; **Immunities** disease, paralyzed, poison, precision, swarm mind, unconscious; **Weaknesses** area damage 20, splash damage 20; **Resistances** fire 10, physical 20

Discorporate As worm that walks.

Speed 30 feet

Melee ❖ tendril +36 (reach 10 feet), **Damage** 4d12+13 persistent piercing damage

Arcane Prepared Spells DC 44, attack +36; **10th** *time stop*; **9th** *disjunction*, *magic missile*, *project image*; **8th** *contingency* (already cast), *illusory scene* (already cast), *mind blank* (already cast); **7th** *reverse gravity*, *fireball*, *veil*; **6th** *baleful polymorph*, *feeblemind*, *true seeing*; **5th** *black tentacles*, *dimension door*, *mind probe*; **4th** *fly*, *invisibility*, *suggestion*; **3rd** *blindness*, *earthbind*, *slow*; **2nd** *glitterdust*, *mirror image*, *ventriloquism*; **1st** *charm*,

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command, *ray of enfeeblement*; **Cantrips (10th)** *acid splash*, *daze*, *electric arc*, *ray of frost*, *shield*

Contingency ↷ **Trigger** The Wriggling Man is reduced to 50 or fewer HP; **Effect** *Dimension door*, heightened to 5th level, teleports the Wriggling Man to area **M6**.

Effortless Concentration ◈ **Trigger** The wriggling man's turn begins. **Effect** The Wriggling Man immediately gains the effects of the Sustain a Spell action, allowing him to extend the duration of an active spell.

Quickened Casting ◈ **Frequency** once per day; **Effect** When the Wriggling Man casts a spell of 8th level or lower, reduce the number of actions to cast it by 1 (minimum 1 action).

Squirming Embrace ❖ As worm that walks, but 8d8 damage and DC 44 basic Reflex save.

Swarm Shape ❖ As worm that walks.

K18. DRESSING CHAMBER

This dressing room has several wardrobes and long mirrors.

Treasure: Long-neglected clothes fill the wardrobes. There are 20 noble outfits and a similar number of courtiers' outfits. A character who succeeds at a DC 30 Perception check finds a beautiful platinum signet ring worth 1,500 gp in the pocket of one of the noble outfits.

K19. RUINED WASHROOM LOW 19

The walls of this forty-foot-high room have fractured, and whatever once decorated it now lies in pulverized fragments heaped in small drifts of sawdust and sand on the floor. This was clearly once some sort of washroom with stone walls and numerous tubs, but now the place is in a shambles.

Creatures: When the House at the Edge of Time was created, the way it distorted and twisted time itself attracted the angry attention of a trio of bythos aeons, but when they arrived to oppose the construction of a structure that warped time and space, they ended up being trapped within it. These same three aeons have remained trapped in this room ever since, and today they exist in a mindset simultaneously of initial fury at discovering the House and of someone who has been trapped in a room for centuries. Nyrissa and her minions avoid this room as a result.

The aeons attack any intruders on sight. While they're elite bythos aeons, they're also limited by the nature of this room—they cannot leave the chamber by any means, including teleportation or planar travel. Worse, unlike other monsters in the House, these three aeons, thanks to their strange association with time itself, also reset whenever the House itself resets, and are restored to life as trapped as ever. Only if Nyrissa is defeated (either by killing her or forgiving her) will these three aeons ever escape.

A PC who is under the protection of the Helix Theorem adds their +4 status bonus from that to their Armor Class against these aeons, as each time the creatures attempt to attack such a PC, flashes of purple energy intervene with a gut-churning hum.

ELITE BYTHOS AEONS (3) CREATURE 17

Pathfinder Bestiary 2 6, 11

Initiative Perception +32

Helix Theorem Feedback: The first time the bythos damages a PC who is protected by the Helix Theorem, the bythos must attempt a DC 40 Fortitude save. The bythos is then

THE WRIGGLING MAN

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HOUSE AT THE EDGE OF TIME: LEVEL TWO
ONE SQUARE = 5 FEET

temporarily immune to this feedback for 1 hour.

Critical Success The aeon is unaffected by the feedback.

Success A flash of light lashes out from the PC to strike the aeon, causing it to be slowed 1.

Failure A flash of light lashes out from the PC to strike the aeon, causing it to be stunned 3.

Critical Failure A flash of light lashes out from the PC to strike the aeon, causing it to be banished from the House at the Edge of Time.

Treasure: The aeons understand the cause of their freedom if the PCs defeat Nyrissa. They *plane shift* to Axis, but within a few days of Nyrissa's defeat, they return to the Material Plane to thank the PCs with an envisioned explanation of the mercy the PCs granted them, along with an orichalcum weapon (choose a weapon used by one of the PCs who would most benefit from the weapon) before they return to Axis.

K20. THE DRIPPING CLOCK

A large and convoluted water clock built to look like a tree, constructed of darkwood, twisted crystal, and bronze tubes, drips quietly away in this dust-layered chamber. The walls of the room are given over to books—hundreds of them.

Creature: The clock continues to tick away the seconds, never losing time as it is inhabited and constantly tended and adjusted by a water mephit named Pludock. While the mephit would never dare to neglect his duty for fear of punishment, he's a chatty creature and can be a useful source of information for the PCs. His initial attitude is indifferent. If made helpful, he happily talks with the PCs. He knows the secret of the healing pool in area **K14** and the danger of damaging the dancing bear in area **K6**; he might be able to inform the PCs of other minor traps or beneficial areas as well. If asked about Nyrissa, he grows silent after saying, "I'd better not say." If forced into talking, he admits that she's likely hiding out in the Fable—a chamber high above that allows her not only to manipulate things in the House but to watch over every room. When he says this, he clamps his hands over his mouth, his eyes bulge as he looks around at the corners of the room... and a moment later, he bursts into an explosion of water, slain by an unhappy Nyrissa via the Fable.

Pludock has no desire for combat, but if he's attacked by the party, he breathes acid to keep the PCs at bay, then flees shrieking through the House's halls, shrieking and crying in panic the whole time.

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PLUDOCK CREATURE 1

Male water mephit (*Pathfinder Bestiary* 151)
Initiative Perception +3

L1. GREAT HALL LOW 19

This huge and ornate chamber has a vaulted ceiling, with supports carved to resemble serpentine dragons holding great beams aloft. Seven statues of a beautiful woman holding a sword, or posing in a seductive way, stand against the walls, along with several chairs and tables. Two long tables with benches sit in the middle of the room astride a large marble statue of a snakelike dragon.

This room serves as a grand banquet hall for when Nyrissa has enough guests to warrant such an occasion, although she hasn't used it for this function since turning her attention to the Stolen Lands. The secret door to the servant's wing can be found with success on a DC 40 Perception check. It hasn't been opened in ages and is somewhat stuck; succeeding at a DC 30 Athletics check is enough to Force it Open.

Creatures: A pair of Nyrissa's pets, lithe and quick wyverns with long, barbed tongues capable of lashing out and pulling prey into their jaws, sleep and play in this chamber. If they sense intruders, they attack on sight, fighting to the death.

BARBTONGUED WYVERNS (2) CREATURE 18

RARE NE HUGE DRAGON

Variant wyverns (*Pathfinder Bestiary* 133)
Perception +29; darkvision, scent (imprecise) 30 feet
Languages Draconic
Skills Acrobatics +34, Athletics +35, Stealth +30
Str +9, **Dex** +6, **Con** +8, **Int** +0, **Wis** +3, **Cha** +4

AC 42; **Fort** +34, **Ref** +30, **Will** +27
HP 330; **Immunities** paralyzed, unconscious
Attack of Opportunity ↷
Savage ↷ As wyvern.

Speed 30 feet, fly 100 feet
Melee ❖ fangs +35 (reach 10 feet), **Damage** 3d12+17 piercing plus 1d6 persistent bleed
Melee ❖ barbed tongue +35 (reach 30 feet), **Damage** 3d6+17 plus Ripping Grab
Melee ❖ stinger +35 (agile, reach 20 feet), **Damage** 3d10+17 piercing plus barbtongued wyvern venom
Pin to the Sky ❖ With incredible force, the barbtongued wyvern whips its tongue and flings barbs from its length. Up to two creatures within 200 feet of the wyvern can be targeted; each creature must attempt a DC 40 Reflex save. The barbtongued wyvern can't use Pin to the Sky again until its next turn.
Critical Success The target is unaffected.
Success The target takes 2d12+3 piercing damage.
Failure The target takes 5d12 piercing damage and is pinned in place, fastened to the underlying magical nature of Thousandbreaths by the barbs (even if not adjacent to a solid surface). It is immobilized until it Escapes. If the creature is under the effects of a spell that would prevent it from being immobilized, Thousandbreaths first attempts a Counteract check against the spell (+27).
Critical Failure As failure, but the target takes 10d12 piercing damage and is slowed 1 until it escapes.
Reel In ❖ **Requirements** The wyvern has a creature grabbed in its tongue. **Effect** The wyvern moves the creature up to 20 feet closer to it.
Ripping Grab ❖ **Requirements** The wyvern's last action was a success with a barbed tongue Strike, or it has a creature grabbed using this action. **Effect** If the target was immobilized by Pin to the Sky, the wyvern first painfully rips it free of the effect, dealing 4d12 piercing damage. Regardless of whether or not the target was previously immobilized, the wyvern Grabs the target until the end of the monster's next turn. The wyvern can't use its tongue to Strike creatures until the Grab ends.
Using Ripping Grab extends the duration of the monster's Grab until the end of its next turn for all creatures grabbed by it. A grabbed creature can use the Escape action to get out of the grab, and the Grab ends for a grabbed creature if the barbtongued wyvern moves away from it.
Barbtongued Wyvern Venom (poison); **Saving Throw** Fortitude DC 40; **Maximum Duration** 6 rounds; **Stage 1** 5d12 poison damage and clumsy 1 (1 round); **Stage 2** 6d12 poison damage and clumsy 2 (1 round); **Stage 3** 7d12 poison damage and clumsy 3 (1 round)

L2. STAIRWELL

These stairs lead up to area **M3**.

L3. GUEST ROOMS

This wing of the House contains four large guest rooms. None of these chambers have been used in a long time, but each seems brand new and ready to receive guests. Temporal ripples and phantoms sometimes flit around the place, echoes of long-departed guests. The PCs may well observe echoes of their own passage through these rooms—harmless but nonetheless disconcerting to see.

L4. STAIRWELL

This flight of spiral stairs leads up to area **M1**.

L5. STAIRWELL

These stairs lead down to area **K12**.

L6. SERVANTS' WING

This wing of the House served as chambers for servants, but since Nyrissa created her ghostly guardians, these

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rooms have gone unused. Areas **L6a** and **L6b** are both bedrooms. **L6c** is a storeroom, while **L6d** is a privy. **L6e** is a lounge stocked with a large number of old (but relatively mundane and worthless) books, while **L6f** is an open room for exercise and gatherings.

L7. THRONE ROOM BRIDGE

This walkway crosses over the throne room (area **K17**) below. The door to area **L8** is one of the few that is kept locked. It is made of ironwood (Hardness 22, HP 100 [BT 50]) and it can be Forced Open with a DC 41 Athletics (expert) check or its Lock can be Picked with a DC 39 Thievery (master) check.

Development: If the Wriggling Man has not yet been encountered, he'll react to intruders on this bridge as detailed in area **K17**.

L8. NYRISSA'S CHAMBERS MODERATE 19

This wing of the House contains Nyrissa's private relaxation chambers, although since the beginning of this chapter, the nymph queen has spent her time in the Fable (area **M7**). All of the rooms in this wing are opulent and extravagant; the function of each is summarized below, but the area's guardians are mobile and quickly react to intrusions, so combat here is likely to spill through multiple chambers.

Area **L8a** is a private ballroom, the walls of which are hung with floral tapestries. The connected washroom (area **L8b**) contains a porcelain tub that fills with hot, scented water on command. Area **L8c** is a study—a Search of the room reveals several sheets bearing flowery script and illustrations of plant and fey creatures. Area **L8d** appears to be Nyrissa's bedroom, but in fact the bed is one of the four entrances to the Fable—it leads to the nymph's true bedroom (area **M7d**; see that area for details on how to travel to the Fable). Area **L8e** is a drawing room, while area **L8f** is a large closet that contains the majority of Nyrissa's impressive collection of clothing. Finally, area **L8g** is a combination reading room and lounge.

Creatures: Although Nyrissa's true valuables are kept elsewhere, enough remain here that she never leaves this suite of rooms unprotected. The safekeeping of these objects, the cleaning and tending of these rooms, and assisting Nyrissa (when she is present) are the duties of eight defaced naiad queens.

Nyrissa once counted these naiads her sisters and friends. Their beauty rivaled her own, but when Nyrissa suffered at the hands of the Eldest, these eight did as well when Nyrissa had the Nightmare Rook pluck out their eyes. These defaced naiads can still see and utilize their gaze attacks, but their beauty has been forever marred, and they spend their days in constant pain and servitude here. They know that Nyrissa is responsible for their unending pain, but they cannot bring themselves to hate her for it. When they notice intruders, they silently move to attack, tears of blood running freely down their cheeks.

DEFACED NAIAD QUEENS (8) CREATURE 15

RARE | CE | MEDIUM | AMPHIBIOUS | FEY | NYMPH | WATER

Variant female naiad queens (*Pathfinder Bestiary* 248)

Perception +28; low-light vision

Languages Aklo, Elven, Sylvan

Skills Acrobatics +28, Athletics +25 (+29 to Swim), Deception +31, Diplomacy +29, Intimidation +31, Nature +28, Performance +31, Stealth +28, Survival +26

Str +0, **Dex** +7, **Con** +6, **Int** +4, **Wis** +5, **Cha** +8

Shame A defaced naiad queen suffers from shame (page 459) when it attacks any target that can cast primal spells, any fey creature, or any creature that can cast divine spells and worships a deity or faith associated with nature or the First World (such as Gozreh, one of the Eldest, or the Green Faith). Forgive Foe can be attempted against a defaced naiad queen with a DC 36 Diplomacy check or Nature check. If a defaced naiad queen is affected by a critical success from Forgive Foe, its eyes are restored and it cries out in relief an instant before it vanishes, returning to the First World as a chaotic neutral naiad queen. As it does so, a wave of emotional thanks

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and inspiration infuse the character who used Forgive Foe, granting them a +3 status bonus to Lore checks and saves against fear effects for 24 hours.

AC 38; **Fort** +27, **Ref** +30, **Will** +26

HP 230; **Weaknesses** cold iron 15, **Resistances** fire 15

Nymph's Tragedy (aura, emotion, enchantment, mental, primal, visual) 30 feet. Creatures that start their turn in this aura must succeed at a DC 33 Will save or become dazzled as their eyes cloud with blood, darkening their vision. This effect persists as long as the creature continues to begin its turn within the aura, even if it can't see the defaced naiad on subsequent turns.

Speed 30 feet

Melee ❖ painful caress +30 (agile, finesse, magical), **Damage** 3d10+14 mental plus Tortuous Touch

Primal Prepared Spells DC 36, attack +28; **8th** *finger of death*, *heal*; **7th** *chain lightning*, *dispel magic*, *fly*; **6th** *baleful polymorph*, *lightning bolt*, *flesh to stone*; **5th** *cone of cold*, *heal* (×2); **4th** *freedom of movement*, *heal* (×2); **3rd** *blindness*, *fear*, *slow*; **2nd** *glitterdust*, *obscuring mist*, *web*; **1st** *fear*, *gust of wind*, *spider sting*; **Cantrips (8th)** *detect magic*, *guidance*, *light*, *ray of frost*, *stabilize*

Primal Innate Spells DC 36, attack +28; **4th** *charm* (at will), **Constant (4th)** *speak with plants*

Agonized Wail ❖ (auditory, emotion, enchantment, fear, mental, primal) The defaced naiad queen unleashes an agonized wail. Each creature within 60 feet must succeed at a DC 33 Will save or become frightened 1 (or, on a critical failure, frightened 2 and fleeing until the end of its next turn). The creature is then temporarily immune to Agonized Wail for 1 hour.

Baleful Gaze ❖ (emotion, enchantment, incapacitation, mental, primal, visual) When a defaced naiad queen fixes her gaze upon a foe within range of her nymph's tragedy aura, the creature must attempt a Will save. On a failure, it is affected as if by nymph's tragedy; if it was already affected by that aura, it also takes 8d6 mental damage (16d6 on a critical failure). A defaced naiad queen can use Baleful Gaze on a given creature only once per turn.

Tortuous Touch A creature struck by the defaced naiad queen's painful caress Strike must attempt a DC 36 Fortitude save. On a failure, painful, jagged wounds open on the creature's body, the pain of which makes it clumsy 1 (clumsy 2 and fall prone on a critical failure). The clumsy condition is permanent until it is removed via an effect like *restoration*.

Treasure: A Search of area **L8a** reveals a dozen different virtuoso handheld musical instruments, one of which is actually a *horn of blasting*.

There are a total of 43 dresses in area **L8f**. 42 of them are worth 200 gp each; the other is actually an elegant (and scandalously cut) dress that duplicates the abilities of a neutral *greater robe of the archmagi*.

M1. ATTIC

MODERATE 19

The wooden floor of this attic space is covered with thick layers of dust. Cobwebs hang in curtain-like sheets, and four skeletons slump against the southern wall. A ladder leads up to a trap door in the ceiling in one corner, with tendrils of thick roots pressing through around its edges from above.

The stairs lead down to area **L4**. The trap door leads up to **M2** but is overgrown above by vines and roots, and as such must be Forced Open with a DC 40 Athletics check.

Creatures: This room has long been abandoned. The skeletal remains are those of four powerful elven

DEFACED NAIAD QUEEN

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HOUSE AT THE EDGE OF TIME: LEVEL THREE
ONE SQUARE = 5 FEET

priestesses of Calistria, enemies Nyrissa captured and imprisoned after her first absorbed kingdom. Rather than transform into ghosts like the other heroes Nyrissa captured, these four priestesses became banshees after finally dying of old age in this room. They rise up instantly as soon as they notice intruders, and fight until destroyed, but even in undeath they cannot leave this room. Unlike the ghostly guards, their religious drive for vengeance has been only magnified in undeath, and as such they do not bear shame at their fate.

BANSHEES (4) CREATURE 17

Pathfinder Bestiary 34
Initiative Perception +32

M2. IVY TOWER LOW 19

This tower looks out over the House grounds, leaning at a vertiginous angle over the courtyard below. The entire area has been covered completely with a nest-like tangle of vegetation.

A character who succeeds at a DC 40 Perception check notes the vine- and root-covered trap door that leads down to area **M1**. The ironwood vines that choke it must be cleared before the trap door can be opened easily; otherwise, it can be Forced Open with success on a DC 40 Athletics check.

Creature: This tower's open rooftop is the den of Nyrissa's elite sard, a creature who takes up the entire space, its tangled roots hanging over the edges. It observes the PCs as they approach, even if they challenge foes down in the courtyard or atop the lower manor walls in areas **K1**–**K2**, but it won't join a fight there unless it is attacked. If someone forces open the trap door from area **M1** below, they won't be able to climb up onto the roof of the tower since the sard occupies that space completely, and the sard gets to roll Athletics for initiative as it shifts its bulk ponderously above. Once roused to anger, the monster pursues foes as best it can, either clambering over the House's roofline or using its melee Strike's reach to attack anyone who tries to retreat into area **M1** for refuge. It abandons pursuit only if the PCs retreat deeper into the House or flee to the lake's far shore; otherwise, it fights to the death.

If the PCs have slain the lesser jabberwock in Part 1, Nyrissa relocates this sard down to area **K2**, in which case this area is empty.

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ELITE SARD **CREATURE 20**

Pathfinder Bestiary 2 6, 231

Initiative Perception +37

M3. THE RUINED HALLS MODERATE 19

This series of rooms, once Nyrissa's private sanctuary, suffered greatly from the nymph's frustrations and wrath after she survived the Eldest's attempt to have her killed by the Jabberwock, and as such serves as an exception to the rule elsewhere in the house that its nature has remained unchanged since its construction. She never bothered restoring these rooms and instead converted the suite at area **L8** to serve as her new private quarters, leaving this area in shambles. Today these rooms are a tangle of thick, creeping vines and plants that have grown riotously to a height of two feet throughout the area, making this entire area greater difficult terrain. In addition, a large number of damaged or destroyed statues of all manner of creatures lie strewn about the place; these were left by this area's dangerous guardian.

Creature: When Nyrissa first began experimenting with the jabberwock's blood in her efforts to create a lesser version of the creature, one of her first attempts involved infusing creatures with the ichor. All but one of these experiments died, but the survivor, a medusa named Phomandala, transformed into a scaly but quite healthy monster with a pair of sizable cobras amid the smaller tangle of her serpentine hair. Phomandala has lived in these ruined halls ever since, serving as a guardian for the upper floors of the House. Over the years, the infusion of jabberwock blood and her life on the First World have slowly granted magical powers as well, and the medusa is now a powerful sorcerer in her own right. Her insights into the nature of primal magic have been a boon for Nyrissa as she continued to absorb kingdoms, helping her to refine the process of creating Blooms. For the last several dozen events on the last several dozen worlds, though, Phomandala has had little to do to further refine the process, and she has instead spent the past century or two in this suite of rooms enjoying a sort of "retirement"—relaxing among her statues, meditating, and carrying on long, complex discussions with visitors that often last for years. Her latest companions are a pair of capricious whimwyrms with whom Phomandala has been debating for almost the entire time this Adventure Path has taken place. With neither the medusa nor the whimwyrms budging on their positions regarding the role of chaos and law in the First World, they've largely not even noticed the advent of this latest round of Blooms.

When the PCs arrive, Phomandala doesn't immediately attack. Instead, she asks the PCs what their take is on the role of law and chaos in the First World. If the PCs react in a way that favors law, she smirks in delight and the whimwyrms attack in anger, but if the PCs react in a way that favors chaos, she shrieks in frustration and attacks instead. Regardless, once the second round of combat begins, the nonparticipant joins in the fight against the PCs. If the PCs attempt to argue that law and chaos are equally important, the medusa and the whimwyrms all attack on the first round.

Phomandala avoids melee if possible, using her spells and Focused Gaze against PCs while relying on her ability to move through the room's difficult terrain with ease to stay out of melee. The whimwyrms open with their breath weapons, then move in to fight in melee. If both whimwyrms are slain, Phomandala uses *revival* to return them to the fight. All three fight to the death, in any event, frustrated at having their debate interrupted when it felt like it was only a few more months away from a proper resolution.

PHOMANDALA **CREATURE 19**

UNIQUE | LE | MEDIUM | DRAGON | HUMANOID

Variant female medusa (*Pathfinder Bestiary* 234)

Perception +32; darkvision

Languages Aklo, Common, Draconic, Sylvan

Skills Acrobatics +35, Arcana +34, Deception +37, Intimidation +37, First World Lore +37, Nature +35, Religion +33

Str +5, **Dex** +8, **Con** +6, **Int** +5, **Wis** +5, **Cha** +10

Items *+2 glamered fortification greater resilient leather armor*, elegant robes worth 400 gp

AC 45, all-around vision; **Fort** +33, **Ref** +35, **Will** +32

HP 300

Petrifying Gaze (arcane, aura, transmutation, visual) 30 feet. As medusa but DC 38.

Biting Snakes ↻ As medusa.

Speed 25 feet

Melee ❖ cobra fangs +32 (reach 10 feet), **Damage** 4d12+13 piercing plus Phomandala's venom

Melee ❖ snake fangs +35 (agile, finesse), **Damage** 4d10+13 piercing plus Phomandala's venom

Primal Spontaneous Spells DC 41, attack +36; **10th** (1 slot) *revival*; **9th** (4 slots) *chain lightning*, *disjunction*, *massacre*, *overwhelming presence*, *heal*; **8th** (4 slots) *dispel magic*, *heal*, *horrid wilting*, *prismatic wall*, *lightning bolt*; **7th** (4 slots) *eclipse burst*, *finger of death*, *mask of terror*, *regenerate*, *wall of thorns*; **6th** (4 slots) *baleful polymorph*, *dragon form*, *heal*, *stone to flesh*, *true seeing*; **5th** (4 slots) *chromatic wall*, *cone of cold*, *heal*, *wall of ice*, *wall of stone*; **4th** (4 slots) *acid arrow*, *charm*, *freedom of movement*, *restoration*, *spell immunity*; **3rd** (4 slots) *blindness*, *fear*, *haste*, *meld into stone*, *slow*; **2nd** (4 slots) *create food*, *enhance victuals*, *glitterdust*, *resist energy*, *web*; **1st** (4 slots) *charm*, *create water*, *gust of wind*, *magic*

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fang, *true strike*; **Cantrips (9th)** *acid splash*, *chill touch*, *detect magic*, *electric arc*, *ghost sound*, *shield*

Sorcerer Bloodline Spells DC 41, attack +36, 3 Focus Points; **9th** *dragon breath*, *dragon claws*, *dragon wings*

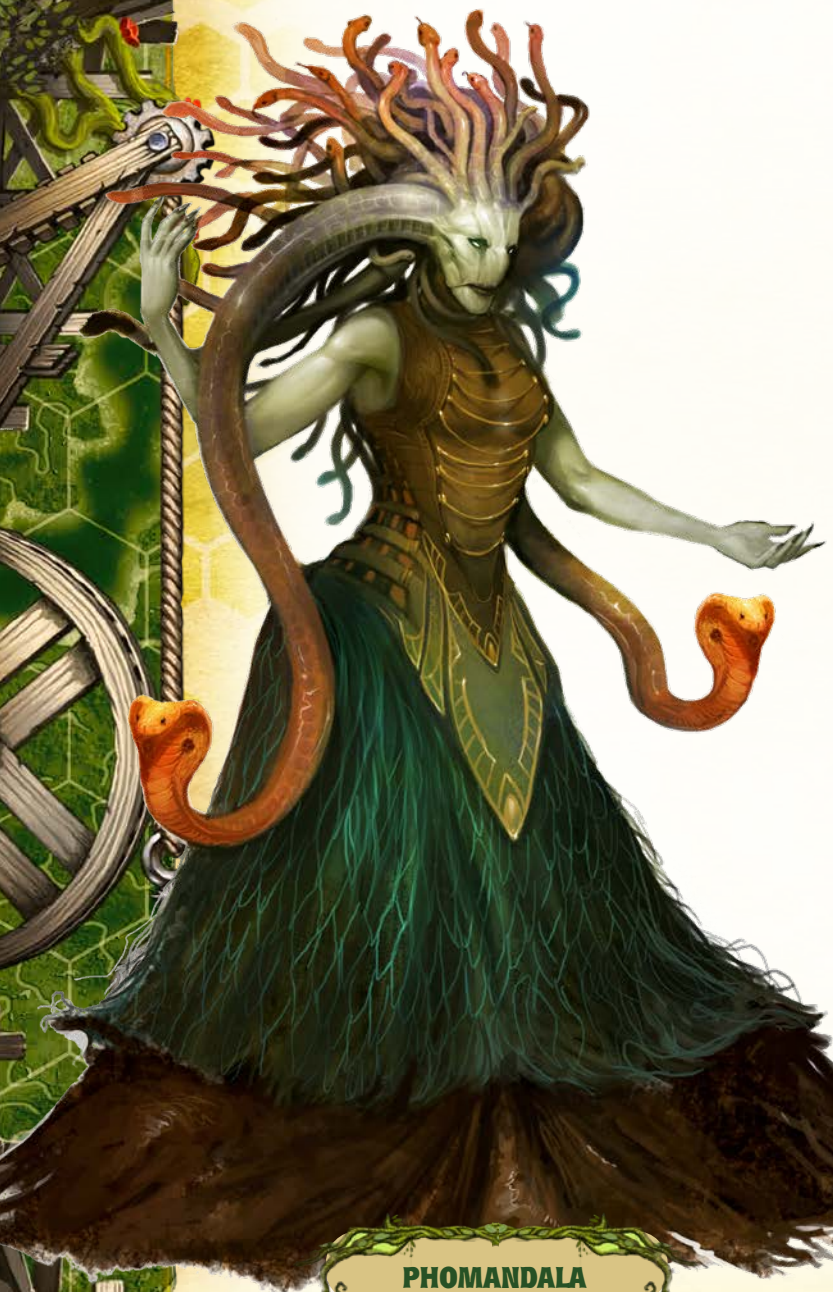
Focus Gaze ❖ (arcane, concentrate, incapacitation, transmutation, visual) As medusa.

Jabberwock Bloodline Phomandala's sorcerer bloodline is a result of Nyrissa's infusion of the medusa with jabberwock blood. This bloodline functions as the draconic bloodline, but the damage type caused is a line of sonic energy, and she uses the primal spell list instead of the arcane spell list.

Quickened Casting ❖ **Frequency** once per day; **Effect** When Phomandala's next action is to cast a spell that is 7th level or lower, she reduces the number of actions to cast it by 1 (minimum 1 action).

Phomandala's Venom (poison); **Saving Throw** DC 41 Fortitude; **Maximum Duration** 6 rounds; **Stage 1** 6d6 poison damage and enfeebled 1 (1 round); **Stage 2** 9d6 poison damage and enfeebled 2 (1 round)

Woodland Stride Even the thickest vines and roots seem to part as Phomandala moves about. Phomandala ignores difficult terrain caused by plants, such as bushes, vines, and undergrowth. Even plants manipulated by magic don't impede her progress.



PHOMANDALA

WHIMWYRMS (2) CREATURE 17

See page 615

Initiative Perception +31

M4. NYRISSA'S LIBRARY

This room is both a laboratory and a library, with numerous large tomes sitting on sagging shelves along the walls and several tables covered with notes and strange schematics.

The majority of the notes on the tables are poetry written by Nyrissa, but if the PCs have unanswered questions about what Nyrissa is up to or why she's out to take the Stolen Lands, they can discover fragmentary notes here to help clear up any lingering last-minute questions that you know don't hinge on the events of Chapter 11. The PCs can also learn about the Fable by studying these notes. A character who succeeds at a DC 30 Nature check or a DC 40 Arcana, Occultism, or Religion check made as part of an hour spent Investigating these notes learns not only what the Fable is capable of and how it works, but also the locations of the four portals that open into the Fable. Such a character also learns the method of opening the portals, as well as the method of leaving the Fable once one is inside it. See area **M7** for these details. If the PCs aren't stealthy about investigating these notes, Nyrissa may notice them from her vantage point in the Fable and alert any surviving minions to make all haste to this area to stop the PCs from learning too much from these carelessly forgotten notes.

Treasure: This library contains a large number of books about the First World, the Stolen Lands, and magic theory. Any Recall Knowledge checks made while using this library to research a topic tied to one of these three subjects gains a +3 item bonus. The collection weighs several hundred pounds in all, but as a set is worth 14,000 gp.

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M5. THE ABANDONED TREASURY

This room is falling into ruin. Plaster hangs from the ceiling, furniture lies buried in fallen leaves, the walls sag, and dust covers everything. Numerous empty and toppled treasure chests strewn about the place hint that it may have once been a grand treasury.

Although it appears close to collapse, the room is structurally sound. This is indeed Nyrissa's treasury, but the majority of the magical items and treasures kept here were taken long ago by the Eldest when they exacted their punishment on Nyrissa. The nymph never bothered restocking the place, instead opting to keep her greatest treasures close at hand.

Treasure: The agents of the Eldest didn't take everything. A 10-minute search of this area reveals bits and pieces of treasure that still remain: a miniature castle of jade wrapped in the coils of a silver serpent (an old table centerpiece designed to hold flowers) worth 6,000 gp, a pig-shaped casket containing 999 pp with each coin set comfortably in its own velvet slot, a gold decanter bound in gold with a ruby stopper worth a total of 8,000 gp, a *greater storm flash*, a gold and ivory scroll tube worth 75 gp that contains a *scroll of dragon form* heightened to 8th level and the formula for the *resurrect* ritual written in Sylvan, and a slightly dented helm that acts as a *greater hat of the magi*.

M6. NYRISSA'S GARDEN MODERATE 19

The vines and leaves of an overgrown garden fill this high chamber, the ceiling of which is obscured by a dense canopy of mold and fungus that hang like wet, glistening sheets. The walls are difficult to make out through the riotous green growth, but at the room's center sits a rippling pool of water.

The pool of water is one of the four entrances to the Fable—it leads to area **M7a**.

Creature: At first glance, this strange garden might seem to be a dualistic display of verdant plant life below and glistening fungus above, both sustained by the life-giving primal energies of Thousandbreaths. In fact, the "fungus" above is a single immense creature—an elite mu spore that has floated quietly within the garden, dreaming strange dreams for the past several centuries. Much smaller than most mu spores, this specimen is still large enough to fill the upper half of this 40-foot-tall room. Anyone other than Nyrissa who enters this room immediately awakens the immense creature. It fills the upper portion of the room so completely that it can't move, but it has no problem reaching creatures on the ground below, and it can even send its tentacles slithering through nearby rooms to "pursue" those who flee.

MU SPORE CREATURE 21

Pathfinder Bestiary 238
Initiative Perception +38

M7. THE FABLES EXTREME 19

For all of the impressive features possessed by the House at the Edge of Time, none can match Nyrissa's greatest creation: an extradimensional tower known as the Fables. This region exists as part of the House, but not wholly in the same place or time. The Fables consist of four relatively tiny, unique, and overlapping demiplanes nested within the demiplane that is Thousandbreaths—each of which are their own Fable.

Entering a Fable: Each of the four Fables are linked to a portal trigger located in the House at the Edge of Time; see the nearby table for a list of these portal triggers and their locations. These portal triggers each radiate powerful primal magic. A character can Identify Magic on a portal trigger with a DC 40 Nature check or a DC 45 Arcana, Occultism, or Religion check. (If none of your PCs are capable of this activity, you should include an opportunity for the PCs to learn how to use portal triggers in this part of the chapter, either learning from an NPC, or discovering the method of opening the portals in a journal—perhaps one found in area **M4**.)

A PC can activate a portal trigger as if it were a magic item by performing two actions—first Interacting with the portal trigger and then by Envisioning a specific thought. A PC who successfully Identifies Magic while studying a portal trigger automatically learns its activating thought, as listed on the nearby table. Once a portal key is activated, the triggering creature and any number of other willing creatures within 60 feet that are chosen by the triggering creature are transported into the corresponding Fable (see the table below).

The contents of each Fable are detailed below, but all four share similar features. When a creature first arrives in a Fable, they do so surrounded by darkness in a twenty-foot diameter "room" at the Fable's heart. A moment later, that darkness lights up, revealing what appears to be an entire realm. In fact, this "realm" is a self-contained demiplane that extends out in a sphere for 100 feet from the center. Attempts to travel beyond this distance meet an impenetrable solid barrier; the "world" beyond exists only as an image along the Fable's internal borders.

A character can exit a Fable by standing within that central 20-foot diameter room at the core (indicated as such on the map on page 472), then taking one action to Envision. This returns the character to the House at

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FABLE PORTALS

Portal Trigger	Activating Thought	Portal Destination
Tallest tree in area **K2**	Flying as a crow through an endless forest	Area **M7b**
Throne in area **K17**	Holding court before a crowd of thousands	Area **M7c**
Bed in area **L8d**	Caressing or embracing a lover	Area **M7d**
Pool in area **M6**	Lying on one's back on the grass in the sun	Area **M7a**

the Edge of Time adjacent to the Fable's corresponding portal trigger.

The individual Fables themselves appear as follows.

Fable M7a: This Fable appears to be a boundless open field under the noontime sun on a bright summer day. In the distance, a thin line of forest obscures the horizon in all directions. The ground bisects the sphere, filling its lower half with solid earth. A "sun" above provides bright light in this Fable.

Fable M7b: This chamber appears to be a single, immensely tall tree that extends forever in either direction inside a silo of impenetrable green leaves, with the tree's 5-foot-wide trunk rising up at the center of the sphere. The number of branches and thick, sturdy leaves allow creatures to move in any direction by Climbing with a DC 20 Athletics check. A critical failure at this check results in a heart-stopping moment when the creature experiences a disorienting "fall" of 1d10 ×10 feet before landing prone at the place where they started the fall, taking falling damage as appropriate (this can occur even when the PC is standing on the Fable's "floor" below). Only by deliberately Climbing or flying up or down can a character change their elevation in this Fable. The tangle of branches provides all creatures with standard cover against ranged Strikes. Shafts of "sunlight" filtering in from above provide bright light in this Fable.

Fable M7c: This chamber appears to be a vast stone plaza in a forest clearing under a moonlit night sky. At the center of the plaza stands a statue of Nyrissa, one arm held out as if in greeting. An inches-deep layer of crystal clear water covers the plaza itself, while the edge of the plaza (and the edge of the Fable itself) is ringed by an impenetrable forest. It is in this room that the House's power is concentrated, and it's here where Nyrissa spends much of her time—from here, she can observe every single room in her House simultaneously as if via *clairvoyance* and *clairaudience*, switching her focus from one room to another by Envisioning. Nyrissa can immediately destroy any of her allies (but not intruders) in the House that she observes from here, taking a single Envisioning action to simply snuff out their lives and causing their bodies to burst. Nyrissa only uses this ability to destroy an ally who has become controlled by or seems to be allying with the PCs (an event likely to occur only with the unfortunate mephit in area **K20**, but if the PCs manage to *dominate* or *charm* an important ally, Nyrissa opts for its destruction as well). Likewise, if the PCs are about to learn something important, the nymph may well send her closest allies to intercept the PCs. Moonlight from above provides dim light in this Fable.

Fable M7d: This chamber is Nyrissa's private bedchamber; it's lit by several everburning torches. Unlike the other three rooms, this chamber's borders are those formed by the twenty-foot-tall room itself, as depicted on the map; this room is what existed at the top of the House's tower before Nyrissa created the Fables.

Creature: Nyrissa spends most of her time in area **M7c** so she can track visitors and intruders in her House, and she goes there as soon as the PCs arrive. If she has reclaimed *Briar*, she has placed the sword in her personal chambers (area **M7d**). Regardless, she watches the PCs' progress through her lair with amusement and, perhaps, a growing sense of worry.

Nyrissa has spent a significant portion of her long years brooding over what she regards as an unjust exile and plotting violent revenge against the Eldest, whose power she still considers to be hers by right. She sees the PCs as the latest manifestation of this betrayal—be it pawns of her enemies or upstarts who don't know their place. If the PCs enter one of the Fables other than area **M7c**, she uses Switch Fable to confront the PCs one round later, after she casts *regenerate* on herself.

If the PCs still possess *Briar* when they confront Nyrissa, she demands it be handed over to her at once. If the PCs deny her, or if they don't have *Briar* with them, she attacks at once. In combat, Nyrissa uses flight to stay at range and relies on her spells and Focus Beauty ability. On the first three rounds of combat, she uses Quickened Casting to cast defensive spells (typically *freedom of movement*, *mirror image*, and *true seeing*), using her remaining actions to cast offensive spells or avoid melee. She saves *wish* to recover from damage or debilitating effects, or to duplicate a *banishment* spell heightened to 9th level to force the PCs back to the Material Plane if they reduce her to fewer than 200 HP or otherwise significantly threaten her. Keep in mind that Nyrissa is both very intelligent and has been watching the PCs for most of the campaign, particularly as they explored her House, and as such you should take some time to adjust her tactics to be specifically tailored against the PCs as you see fit—although the

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focus of her attacks should usually remain a character who wields *Briar* against her.

If the PCs have already managed to uproot Thousandbreaths, Nyrissa's confidence is shaken and she is frightened 1 during her first combat with the PCs; this condition is removed if the PCs retreat from a fight, allowing her confidence to return. The DC to Forgive Foe on Nyrissa if Thousandbreaths is uprooted is reduced to 46.

If Nyrissa is reduced to fewer than 100 hit points, she Switches Fables if she can to recover as best she can before returning to face the PCs again a minute later if they remain in a Fable. If she can't Switch Fables, she instead exits the Fable normally, returning to that Fable's linked portal trigger area. If the PCs prevent her from reaching the central 20 feet of a Fable and she has no further avenue of escape, she calls for a truce to speak to the PCs.

In this case, or if the PCs manage a critical success against her with Forgive Foe, or if the PCs manage to defeat her and capture her alive, they can speak to her as detailed at the start of Chapter Eleven.

NYRISSA

NYRISSA CREATURE 23

See page 602

Initiative Perception +41

Treasure: If Nyrissa reclaimed *Briar*, the weapon lies casually tossed on the bed in area **M7d**. That room also contains a large number of trophies and prizes she has picked up or had her minions collect over the years, all of which have been collected from the Stolen Lands and help to focus the Fable upon this region. If these trophies are taken out of the Fable, Nyrissa cannot bottle the Stolen Lands until they are regained. These trophies consist of things such as a unicorn's horn, a silver dragon's claw, a tooth from Armag's skull, and so on. Add other objects that the PCs at one time possessed but have since lost or sold. The more unique and recognizable these items are—like *Ovinrbaane*, the *Oculus of Abaddon*, or the *Stag Lord's helm*—the more disturbing and shocking they will be for the PCs to find. Even items the PCs have destroyed can appear here, fully functional once more. Only if the PCs retained such treasures or locked them away safely should these things not appear here as trophies. Amid all of these treasures are numerous other obscure and expensive ritual supplies amounting to 2,000 gp in all for use in performing *primal call* rituals.

Perhaps the greatest treasure in area **M7d**, though, is the *Apology*. This glowing, bejeweled chalice sits on a nightstand near the bed, nearly filled with 999 glowing grains of sand—each of which represents a previously claimed kingdom. It is into this chalice that Nyrissa hopes to place the PCs' kingdom as the final grain of sand. Rules for this powerful artifact are not presented in this adventure, as its goal is to serve more of a story element than to serve as a reward for the PCs or a viable tactic for Nyrissa to use against them in the final confrontation, but a few additional notes about it appear on page 586 of Appendix 4 in this book.

CONCLUDING THE CHAPTER

With Nyrissa's defeat, a great threat to the PCs' kingdom—indeed, all of the Stolen Lands—is removed. If the nymph dies (likely to an unfortunate beheading from a sword forged of her own capacity to love), a strange and violent transformation ripples through Thousandbreaths. If it hasn't yet been uprooted, it is uprooted immediately—including the House at the Edge of Time. The House quickly crumbles and suffers thousands of years of erosion at once as if inflicted by constricting vegetation, rainfall, lightning strikes, and subsidence, effectively transforming into the ruins known today as the Castle of Knives. The Fables vanish, leaving behind area **M7d** as a normal room at the top of the tower. If the PCs were in another Fable at this time, they appear in this room. Regardless, any PCs in the House at the Edge of Time as it transposes to the Material Plane and erodes are protected from the swift decay all around them unless they fail a DC 40 Fortitude save, in which case they are drained 1 by the event.

During this reversion, Nyrissa's body rises up on a pyre of black lightning. As it does, a terrible gale rips through all of Thousandbreaths. The Queen's body acts as the center of this vortex and soon vanishes in a black pall of clouds. Within a minute, the unraveling is over. The House finishes its collapse and the surviving denizens of the building and Thousandbreaths flee into the strange new world they find themselves in.

While the PCs have defeated Nyrissa, though, one danger remains: it won't be long before the Lantern King makes his frustrations known.

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CHAPTER 11

CURSE OF THE LANTERN KING

BY STEVEN T. HELT, TIM HITCHCOCK, AND JAMES JACOBS

PART 1: A BROKEN APOLOGY 480
The PCs should be 20th level before facing the results of the broken *Apology*.

PART 2: THE LANTERN KINGDOM 484
The PCs should be 20th level before they are swept into the Lantern Kingdom.

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PART 1:

A BROKEN APOLOGY

While the PCs have defeated the threat Nyrissa posed to their kingdom, her death or redemption creates an unexpected complication, for the Lantern King has waited with growing impatience for the final kingdom to be absorbed into the *Apology*. With Nyrissa slain or forgiven, this seems unlikely, and it's only a matter of time before the Lantern King shatters the *Apology* and unleashes his wrathful curse on those responsible for disrupting his entertainment: the PCs.

TWIN CONCLUSIONS

Assuming the PCs weren't defeated themselves, the previous chapter ends in one of two ways: with Nyrissa's death or with her being forgiven. In the unlikely event that she escapes, it'll be only a matter of time before she tracks down the PCs and attempts to kill them again, giving the party another chance to defeat her or, perhaps, forgive her.

Regardless of how long it takes for either of these possible conclusions to occur, the Lantern King's reaction to the event is the same, and he pulls the objects of his frustration—the PCs—into a self-contained reality known as the Hunting Dream. What happens before the PCs experience the Hunting Dream depends on how they dealt with Nyrissa.

NYRISSA SLAIN

If the PCs killed Nyrissa, then all of Thousandbreaths, the House at the Edge of Time included, collapses and merges with the Material Plane as detailed at the end

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of Chapter 10. Once all is said and done, the PCs are returned to their kingdom, standing before the ruins of the Castle of Knives. However, one thing is different: the now empty *Apology* sits on a slab of stone before them, shining and shimmering with power. Whether the PCs leave the *Apology* where it sits or take it with them is irrelevant, for the Lantern King destroys it the next time the PCs rest—as described in the Hunting Dream below.

NYRISSA FORGIVEN

If the PCs forgive Nyrissa and spare her life, the defeated nymph queen becomes sorrowful and sullen. At this point, she morosely tells the PCs the tale of her rise and fall in power, of her failed attempt to challenge the Eldest, of how the Lantern King took her love to forge *Briar*, and of the Eldest's promise to restore her place in the First World once she absorbed a thousand kingdoms into the *Apology*. If the PCs didn't achieve a critical success at Forgive Foe to get to this point with her, they can impress upon her their forgiveness simply by saying so; no skill check is required unless the PCs are attempting to Lie to her.

Nyrissa agrees to any PC demand to leave their kingdom in peace, and she does so honestly. Any treasures the PCs acquired while exploring her realm are theirs to keep, she adds—"Payment for your mercies," as she puts it. She asks only that the PCs leave *Briar* with her, but if they refuse, she won't press the matter again until the topic of the Lantern King's reaction comes up (see below). Requests from the PCs for her aid in rebuilding their kingdom are met with a scoffing laugh unless the PCs can convince Nyrissa that they truly wish to help her and forgive her by adjusting her attitude to be friendly by Making an Impression (her initial attitude is unfriendly unless the PCs honestly forgive her, in which case her initial attitude is indifferent). If she's made friendly, Nyrissa feels a faint glimmer of hope for the first time in a long time, and she cautiously tells the PCs that she'll "consider the offer."

At some point during the discussion, though, the subject of the Lantern King comes up. Nyrissa knows the demigod's anger and frustration at her not filling the *Apology* is inevitable, and while she knows that he won't be able to leave these developments alone, she's not sure what form his frustration will take other than that it will certainly affect the PCs as much as—if not more than—herself. The PCs, she warns, should be ready for anything.

On the subject of *Briar*, Nyrissa knows the only way to regain her ability to love while she still lives is to have the Lantern King unmake the weapon. She bitterly observes that "if he can't be convinced by words, my only hope is to convince him by force." She agrees at this time to let the PCs to keep *Briar* for the short term if they promise to help her secure the Lantern King's cooperation, but makes it abundantly clear that her hope is that the sword itself will soon be unmade.

Finally, regarding the *Apology*, Nyrissa admits that the artifact was given to her by the Lantern King and that the grains of sand within it each represent one of the 999 previously conquered kingdoms. She isn't sure whether those absorbed kingdoms are destroyed, in stasis, or something else, and muses that if anyone knows, it would be the Lantern King. What she can explain to the PCs is that the process by which a mortal kingdom is conquered and then absorbed as a grain of sand is a mystery even to her, although she can (and sometimes has) granted certain people from kingdoms about to be absorbed mercy to remain as her minions at times in the past. If the PCs fear that the *Apology* can still be used to absorb their kingdom, Nyrissa truthfully tells them that, now that she has been forgiven, she has no intention of continuing to pursue this goal. While the wrath of the Lantern King is certainly coming, the PCs and their subjects no longer have anything to fear from Nyrissa herself.

KINGDOM IN THE BACKGROUND

As the campaign nears its conclusion, the PC's kingdom has become a powerful political force in the River Kingdoms, but it still faces one final danger: the Lantern King's petulance. The kingdom's presence in this last chapter is mostly reflected in the "what if" realm presented by the Lantern King, but you should adjust the encounter descriptions as needed to match the sort of kingdom you've described the PCs building during the Adventure Path.

THE HUNTING DREAM EXTREME 20

The Lantern King's reaction to the PCs is coming, and sooner than they can make any significant preparations for. The demigod takes note of Nyrissa's defeat the moment it happens, but preparing his reaction takes a short time as he reshapes a portion of his own realm in the First World into a demiplane called the Hunting Dream. When this occurs, the sleeping PC simply fades away from the world, evaporating painlessly from reality only to form in this other one. The process does not cause the sleeping PC to waken, but will surely distress anyone watching the event occur. It's best, as a result, to have this take place when all of the PCs are slumbering, but if that proves difficult to time, you can simply have the Lantern King pull awake PCs from the Material Plane into the Hunting Dream. This transition carries less symbolic effect, but the end result—

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TRAPPED IN A CURSE

Once the PCs escape the Hunting Dream, they become trapped in the Lantern Kingdom. This isn't meant to cut them off from their companions entirely. As this part ends and the next part begins, work with your players to decide what companions, if any, they may wish to bring with them into the Lantern Kingdom. Those associated with the PCs' classes, such as familiars or animal companions, should be allowed to accompany them even if they were not present when they were pulled into the dream. Whether or not you allow NPC companions to come with the PCs is left to you. The PCs can also bring with them any items they may have not had on them at the time they were drawn into the Hunted Dream. If the PCs have additional magic items they wish to craft, identify, or sell consider delaying the start of the Hunted Dream until the PCs can get these affairs in order, since once the next part begins, there's no turning back!

becoming trapped in another realm—is identical.

The timing of when the Hunting Dream occurs can be tricky; you want it to take place soon after Nyrissa's defeat so that the Lantern King doesn't seem lackadaisical in his pursuit of vengeance, but you should also give the PCs time to wrap up any lingering tasks before moving on with this chapter, as once they are drawn into the Hunting Dream they will not be able to return home with ease—see the "Trapped in a Curse" sidebar for more advice.

The moment of the dream's beginning is impossible for the PCs to pinpoint, as it starts with the PCs exactly as they were when they slept. Describe to the PCs that they wake from sleep to the sound of a hunting horn and the overwhelming feeling that something is coming for them. Regardless of how the PCs react or where they began the dream, the scene quickly changes, with the PCs suddenly finding themselves together, fleeing through a tangled woodland to the sound of pursuit not far behind them.

After what seems like an hour of running, the PCs emerge into a stockaded compound. Bodies lie strewn on the ground, and it should only take a few moments for the PCs to recognize the scene: they've returned to the Stag Lord's fort, and the bodies are those of the bandits they defeated, although the body of the Stag Lord himself is strangely absent. At this point, return control of the PCs' actions to the players and allow them to explore and move about the fort, using the maps on page 176–177. While the fort itself remains structurally the same, strange plants now grow within the fort's courtyard and cling to its wooden walls, while the sky above has unsettling purple and gray spiral clouds against a bright blue sky. Success on a DC 35 Religion check or a DC 30 First World check to Recall Knowledge is enough to deduce that this place, be it dream or reality, lies somewhere in a living dream lodged between the First World and the Dreamlands.

The nature of the Hunting Dream doesn't impact the PCs in many ways—treat it as if they were located in the real ruins of the Stag Lord's fort on the Material Plane for the most part. Attempts to leave the area depicted on the map itself, though, automatically fail. A character who tries to teleport away simply reappears in the same spot, while someone who tries to physically walk beyond the borders of the map itself finds themselves being turned around and approaching the fort. Once a character experiences this effect, they can attempt a DC 35 Occultism check to realize that they are trapped in some form of living dream.

Once the PCs realize they're trapped in a living dream, they'll also know that while they cannot be truly slain in this place, they also cannot escape until they see the dream's elements out to their conclusion.

Creatures: At about the point the PCs realize they're all together in the center of the Stag Lord's fort (area **C5** on page 178), they'll also notice that they're surrounded by strange looking creatures: agents of the wild hunt. These particular wild hunt fey serve the Lantern King, and consist of four wild hunt archers, four wild hunt scouts, and a wild hunt monarch who bears an unsettling resemblance in appearance to the Stag Lord himself, although with tiny motes of electricity dancing along his antlers. The monarch's appearance isn't intended to trick the PCs into thinking that they once again face the Stag Lord himself, though, and it should be obvious to them that the figure who has taken his form is an entirely different creature.

Despite this, the wild hunt monarch introduces himself to the PCs as "the true Stag Lord—champion of the Lantern King and arbiter of your fates." He demands the PCs explain why they dared disrupt Nyrissa's "path to forgiveness," implying that the PCs were in the wrong and were the aggressors rather than the nymph queen herself. He produces the once again full *Apology* in one hand, holding the artifact aloft as he notes that "999 kingdoms lie within this chalice—who are you to deny it one more?" The Stag Lord monarch wishes to hear from the PCs' own mouths their justification for disrupting the Lantern King's entertainment—give each player a chance to argue their case or attempt to contradict the Stag Lord monarch's claims while the other wild hunt fey look on, periodically jeering or mocking the PCs in their attempts to "escape the Stag Lord's judgments."

Once the Stag Lord monarch grows tired with the

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PCs, or once the PCs themselves grow too aggressive or violent, he shakes his head in sadness and declares that their lives are "forfeit to the Lantern King in payment for meddling in affairs beyond their ken." At this point, he raises the *Apology* to his lips, drinks deep of the sand within, and orders an attack on the PCs (assuming the PCs haven't yet instigated hostilities themselves).

Note that this is an extreme encounter for a group of 20th-level PCs, and as such it's very likely that some or all of the characters will perish in the resulting fight. Fortunately, the nature of the Hunting Dream is such that they begin this combat at full health, as if they'd rested well and just finished performing their daily preparations. Give the players time to prepare for the combat before rolling initiative. Once the fighting starts, the battle itself plays out normally (use the map of the Stag Lord's fort on page 176–177 for this fight), but PCs who are slain in this encounter aren't actually killed—see "Dream Defeat" or "Dream Victory" below.

STAG LORD MONARCH — CREATURE 20

CE male Wild Hunt monarch (page 620)
Initiative Perception +35

WILD HUNT SCOUTS (4) — CREATURE 18

See page 619
Initiative Perception +34

WILD HUNT ARCHERS (4) — CREATURE 16

See page 618
Initiative Perception +30

Dream Defeat: If the wild hunt manages to kill all of the PCs, describe the final blow not as an attack, but as one of the members of the hunt (the monarch if he lives) raising the *Apology* over their head to smash it down upon the final PC. As it strikes the "killing blow" to that character, the *Apology* shatters and the grains of sand contained within surge outward in a vortex of chaos in which all of the PCs, be they "living" or "dead" at this point, feel 999 simultaneous existences in 999 simultaneous worlds filled with anguish and torment before everything goes dark. The PCs awaken in the Lantern Kingdom, as detailed at the start of Part 2, but when they do so, they are all doomed 1 as a result of dying in the Hunting Dream.

Dream Victory: If at least one PC remains alive to defeat the wild hunt, describe the final blow or spell that ends the last of the fey cutting through to smash against the *Apology*, which suddenly shatters in a blinding blast of golden light. The explosion results in the same disorienting vortex of chaos as described in Dream Defeat above. The PCs (including any who died during this fight) awaken in the Lantern Kingdom, as detailed at the start of Part 2, but as a result of their victory over the wild hunt, not only are none of the PCs doomed 1, but they are all restored to full health and capacity, as if they had benefited from a full night of rest and had just completed their daily preparations for the day's adventures to come.

THE LANTERN KING'S CURSE

At the end of the Hunting Dream, the *Apology* is shattered. This event occurs both in the Hunting Dream itself and in reality. As the *Apology* is shattered, the power of nine hundred and ninety-nine kingdoms at once are unleashed, allowing the Lantern King to instantly create a self-contained demiplane based on a theoretical apocalyptic future of the PCs' kingdom in the Stolen Lands. The Lantern King invests a significant portion of his own being in this act, manifesting a living aspect of himself and also trapping the PCs and any of their companions within.

This is the curse of the Lantern King—that all who have ever sought the throne are doomed to wage eternal conflict, earning empty victories only to make the same war again tomorrow. To the PCs, the Lantern Kingdom appears as a shattered version of their own home, where they face familiar enemies they once thought they defeated. Simultaneously the defeated heroes of the other 999 kingdoms face their own apocalyptic nightmares as well, after enduring countless eons being trapped in a grain of sand. These realities exist atop each other but do not overlap—the PCs are unlikely to ever become aware of the true nature of the Lantern Kingdom, but regardless, they alone can do something to finally end this long-lasting torment.

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PART 2:

THE LANTERN KINGDOM

When the Hunting Dream concludes and the *Apology* is destroyed, an apocalyptic reality is created: the Lantern Kingdom. It's into this devastated "what-if?" reality that the PCs awaken from the Hunting Dream, trapped in a realm that imagines what their kingdom would be like after its destruction at the burning touch of an enraged Lantern King.

THE RAVAGED CAPITAL

When the PCs first wake in the Lantern Kingdom, they do so in a region both familiar and horrifically unknown: the heart of their own capital, but after a devastating apocalypse has torn the settlement to shreds. All that remains of the city are five slabs of uprooted terrain that float in the air at different altitudes. Above, as below, the sky and ground have been replaced by what appear to be glowing panes of fiery glass within which these fragments of the PCs' capital now lie suspended. After gazing out upon the strange horizon, success at a DC 20 Perception check is all that's required to realize that it all seems to be housed in a single vast lantern, its glass panes inverted so that the flame that glows to provide illumination shines in from beyond. Characters who peer long enough into those distant glass panes may periodically catch glimpses of other entirely unknown worlds, each of which suffers in the fires of their own private apocalypse. These are windows into the other 999 kingdoms that were once contained in the *Apology*, but there is no way to reach these realities from within the Ravaged Capital itself.

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The Lantern Kingdom is a small, finite demiplane encased entirely within a single lantern that hangs in the Lantern King's throne room in the First World. As the PCs explore the Ravaged Capital, they occasionally catch glimpses beyond the distant glass borders of an immense burning sphere topped by a jagged crown of horns—the Lantern King watching from beyond as the PCs suffer and toil for his amusement. Divination magic can serve to reveal some of the truths of this realm to the PCs, as can speaking to the few friendly NPCs they encounter along the way. Alternately, a PC can take ten minutes Investigating the environment, after which they can attempt a DC 40 Arcana, Nature, Occultism, or Religion check. Success indicates they recognize they're within a strange demiplane that seems to exist entirely within a single immense lantern, while a critical success confirms that it is the Lantern King who watches them from the far side of the demiplane's glass borders.

ARRIVAL IN THE LANTERN KINGDOM

Whether the Hunting Dream resulted in the Wild Hunt defeating the PCs or in the PCs being victorious, the dream's end is the same—the *Apology* is shattered and the PCs black out, only to awaken in the Lantern Kingdom. The PCs may initially suspect they've simply moved from one dream to another, but as strange as the environment seems, it is very real. Success at a DC 35 First World Lore or DC 40 Nature check to Recall Knowledge identifies the realm as an unknown demiplane that lies between the First World and the Material Plane. A critical success suggests to the PC the high probability that this demiplane was constructed from metaphysical "echoes" of the kingdoms once contained within the *Apology* itself.

If the PCs survived the Hunting Dream, they waken from it refreshed and in perfect health, as if they'd had a full night's rest and had just finished their daily preparations, as they were at the start of the Hunting Dream. The PCs arrive at area **A1**.

FEATURES OF THE LANTERN KINGDOM

The Lantern Kingdom consists of five separate areas: island-like regions that are each based on a different part of the PCs' capital city. The Lantern Kingdom as a whole serves as a sort of obstacle course the PCs must navigate, a testing ground created by the Lantern King for his amusement, with a chance to meet with him being the reward to PCs if they are clever, brave, or stubborn enough to make it to the end. As such, the PCs find that as long as they remain close to the ground on the floating islands within the Lantern Kingdom, they remain relatively safe, but any attempt to circumvent the course—or worse, approach the Kingdom's glass borders—quickly reveals itself to be deadly; see Travel on the next page for details.

WHERE IS NYRISSA?

If Nyrissa still lives, she too has been trapped within this demiplane, but–unlike the PCs, whom the Lantern King has placed where he can be entertained by them–Nyrissa is ensconced within a cage at the Lantern King's side (page 500). As the PCs explore the Lantern Kingdom, they periodically hear Nyrissa's voice calling for help as if over a great distance from somewhere far above.

The Lantern Kingdom demiplane has the following unusual features.

Size

The demiplane is finite in size. The lantern itself is 5 feet across where it hangs in the Lantern King's realm on the First World, but it is much larger on the inside where the PCs have become trapped. The islands float near the center of the spherical orb, such that the glass borders are just about a mile from the edges of the islands themselves.

Illumination

The Lantern Kingdom is brightly lit at all times, either by the surrounding glass borders or by glowing motes of light that hover near the ceiling of internal locations. This illumination resists the creation of magical darkness. One minute after a magical darkness effect is created, or at the end of a combat in which such an effect is created (whichever comes first), the Lantern Kingdom attempts to counteract the darkness effect (+40 counteract check). If it fails to counteract the magical darkness, the Lantern Kingdom automatically attempts a new counteract check once every 24 hours (unless, of course, the darkness effect ends before then).

Islands

The islands in the Lantern Kingdom float at different altitudes. The group of islands that constitute the Market (where the PCs first arrive in the Lantern Kingdom), is the lowest, with the Residence, the Nobles, the Park, and the Palace each 100 feet higher than the last. As such, it's impossible to see much more than the basic shape of an island above, while one can look down to a bird's-eye view of any island that lies below. The islands themselves are stable; though seemingly floating in the air, there is no sensation to those standing on them that they are on anything other than solid ground. In some places, small gaps in the landscape might force harrowing leaps over the void below. While you can build up some of the perceived

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dangers of doing so, unless the distance being jumped is more than 5 feet across you shouldn't ask for Athletics checks to successfully navigate the gap. Characters who tumble through such a gap fall as detailed under "Falling" below.

Travel

The streets of the ruined capital that lie upon the Lantern Kingdom's islands are strewn with rubble and overgrown with strange First World plants. All ground travel is difficult terrain (from tangled undergrowth outside of buildings, and from rubble and debris inside of buildings) as a result. There are no restrictions on flight, provided the flying character doesn't stray further than 60 feet from the ground. Any attempt to move further than 60 feet from the ground via flight (be it straight up or out from the edge of an island) results in a painful flash of searing light that inflicts 10d6 fire damage (DC 40 basic Reflex save) to the flying creature and prevents further movement in the prohibited direction—the Lantern King wants his entertainment to travel through the kingdom along the route he chose rather than to skip entire islands by flight. "North" in the Lantern Kingdom isn't the result of a magnetic pull but the Lantern King's will.

Planar Travel

It's possible for a PC to escape the Lantern Kingdom via planar travel through effects like *plane shift* or being sent away by spells like *banishment*. Deliberate travel to the Lantern Kingdom is possible via *plane shift* (provided the PCs can secure the incredibly rare tuning fork for this, which is subject to GM approval) or *gate*, but as long as the Lantern King hasn't been successfully challenged in his throne room (page 497), any PC who escapes the Lantern Kingdom returns the next time they fall asleep or lose consciousness. Regardless of how a PC travels to the Lantern Kingdom, they always appear in area **A1**.

Falling

It's possible to fall from the edge of an island, but one who falls never lands where logic would dictate. A character who falls plummets 100 feet and lands on the next lower island at its lowest-numbered encounter area, regardless of where the fall began, and even if that area is inside of a structure. A character who falls from the Market instead falls 200 feet before landing at area **A1**.

Creatures

Just as the Lantern Kingdom's geography is based

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on the PCs' capital, some of its "citizens" are warped duplicates of NPCs from home—some appearing as old enemies, and some as friends. For the latter, choose living NPCs who have leadership roles in the PCs' kingdom or other trusted allies, excluding any who have accompanied the PCs into the Lantern Kingdom. If you're using the *Kingmaker Companion Guide*, any of the companions in that book who remained behind on the Material Plane make great choices.

Resting

The Lantern King allows the PCs to rest on any one island once, out of "fairness" to keep the entertainment going. If the PCs attempt to rest on the same island more than once, they'll be attacked at some point during the rest by a group of four wild hunt scouts (a Moderate 20 encounter) who haughtily warn the PCs to not dawdle—to "keep moving or suffer." If the PCs refuse, they must defeat the wild hunt, after which they earn the chance for the additional rest. Each additional rest on that island adds one wild hunt scout to the resulting encounter, to a maximum of a dozen scouts (an Extreme 20 encounter). There are enough constantly blooming fruits and berries among the foliage overgrowing the shattered city, along with small pools of water here and there that refill magically over time, so that PCs who are trapped for many days in the Lantern Kingdom can Subsist with a DC 35 Survival check. A character who rolls a critical failure while attempting to Subsist attracts trouble in the form of a group of four Wild Hunt scouts, as detailed above.

THE MARKET

The lowest island grouping appears to have been ripped from the mercantile heart of the PCs' capital. Use the Market map for encounters that take place here, but feel free to alter the shape of the region or the names of buildings found therein to match locations that are more familiar to the PCs from their own capital.

A1. A FAMILIAR PLACE

When the PCs arrive in the Lantern Kingdom, they do so here. As you present the readaloud text below, you should adjust it as needed to make it apparent that the shop into which they appear is one that they frequent in their capital—if not a place the PCs helped to build, then certainly one that they often visit.

This ruined shop instills a vague sense of deja-vu, while the vista looking out from a mostly collapsed wall is entirely new: a gulf of swirling clouds in which fragments of a familiar city float on rocky islets overgrown with a tangle of alien plant life. Some of these isles are only a few feet across, connected to others by tangles of vines, while one much larger island looms in the sky a hundred feet above in the other direction. Here, glimpses of a ruined, overgrown city are visible, as is a rising "bridge" of thorny vines that winds up from this island grouping to the one above. In the distance, what appear to be vast shimmering fields of glass look out over a void of scintillating light in which drift glimpses of a vast, drifting, burning sphere surrounded by clouds of runes—a sphere that gives you the unmistakable sensation that it is watching.

Add as many other elements as you wish to make it apparent to the PCs that they have appeared not only in a familiar, but ruined store, but within the shattered remains of their own capital. No recognizable NPCs, living or dead, are apparent, and the longer the PCs remain in this realm, the more they should notice strange errors or inconsistencies with what should otherwise be familiar places, as if this shattered city were a duplicate created by someone not wholly familiar with the source. Strange spellings for street names, slightly different images on building signs, and fragmentary statues depicting villains the PCs have previously clashed with are great examples of such off-kilter elements.

Success on a DC 30 Nature or Religion check identifies the "vast burning sphere" that seems to be observing the PCs as the Lantern King himself.

A2. FAMILIAR FACES? MODERATE 20

As the PCs step out of the ruined shop at area **A1**, describe to them another familiar (but ruined) building here that represents another shop they frequent that, in their actual capital, but is not normally located next door to the first. This should help the PCs (and thus the players) recognize they're in a warped reality rather than in their actual capital after some sort of unknown apocalypse destroyed it.

Creatures: This building is currently occupied by four fetch stalkers created in the images of people the PCs have allied with. They emerge from this shop soon after the PCs arrive in the Lantern Kingdom in area **A1**, loudly calling out the PCs' names and daring them to "step out into the open to face their failures."

These fetches accuse the PCs of leaving them behind while their kingdom fell, and demand retribution in the form of execution. A PC can see through the fetches' claims that they're actual survivors from the PCs' fallen kingdom as normal, but even if the fetch stalkers successfully Lie to the entire party, it's likely that the PCs won't trust these figures. The fetches don't waste too much time arguing, and attack soon after they find the PCs.

FETCH STALKERS (4) CREATURE 18

See page 612

Initiative Perception +30

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A3. STRANGE TAVERN LOW 19

This small building appears to be in better condition than the others in the Market. The building itself should be based on a tavern from the PCs' capital, although strangely reduced in size so as to accommodate only the main room. Doors or halls that, in the real world, lead to other parts of the tavern should simply provide alternate exits and entrances to this main chamber.

Creature: Only one being occupies this tavern—one of the Lantern King's loyal agents, the gimmerling Werendegar. Among other things, Werendegar (who introduces himself simply by the name "Weren") has been responsible for moving *Briar* to new hiding places each time Nyrissa absorbs a kingdom and moves on to a new world. Now that this task is no longer needed due to the PCs' actions, the Lantern King has given Werendegar a new job: welcoming the PCs to the Lantern Kingdom. The gimmerling does his best to hide his frustration at this "babysitting" task.

As soon as the PCs defeat the fetches at area **A2,** Werendegar makes himself known by stepping out of the tavern where he has been relaxing. He appears to the PCs in his true form, that of a handsome but clawed and sharp-toothed half-elven man. He greets the PCs by name, then welcomes them to the Lantern Kingdom and notes that they may have questions—and he's eager to give them answers.

Werendegar's purpose here is to encourage the PCs to make their way to the throne room (page 497) to present their case to the Lantern King himself—should they be allowed to live and return home? Werendegar further explains to the PCs that in order to earn this audience with the Lantern King, they must first provide him entertainment in the form of their struggles to reach him. They must prove themselves as "true adventurers worth his time" by navigating their shattered city and triumphing over enemies they thought defeated (this is a reference to several fetches that present to the PCs in familiar forms). He also informs the PCs that when they "broke the *Apology*" (if needed, he'll clarify that he's talking about the chalice that was shattered in the Hunting Dream), they insulted the Lantern King. He tells the PCs that the *Apology* was offered to Nyrissa out of the "Lantern King's inestimable mercy," and that if the PCs wish to leave the Lantern Kingdom, they must rebuild the *Apology* by recovering its three shards, which have been scattered throughout "your broken home" (he indicates the shattered capital all around him at this point).

WERENDEGAR

Once the PCs have all three shards of the *Apology* and make their way to the throne room, Werendegar promises that the Lantern King will make time to hear their pleas for mercy. He provides honest answers for any questions the PCs have about the nature of the Lantern Kingdom. Questions about the Lantern King or himself, though, Werendegar answers more obliquely, implying that the PCs should save those questions for the Lantern King. He won't offer any other unsolicited advice.

Once Werendegar grows bored or annoyed with the PCs, or as soon as he has been attacked, he smirks and says, "see you soon!" before he flees—using *disappearance* and/or *dimension door* to retreat to area **D2** to await the PCs there.

WERENDEGAR CREATURE 21

UNIQUE | CN | SMALL | FEY

Variant male gimmerling (*Pathfinder Bestiary* 177)

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Perception +35, hungersense (imprecise), low-light vision
Languages Aklo, Common, Elven, Gnomish, Sylvan
Skills Acrobatics +39, Athletics +37, Deception +41, Nature +39, Society +35, Stealth +39, Thievery +37
Str +6, **Dex** +10, **Con** +7, **Int** +8, **Wis** +6, **Cha** +10
Items *+2 greater resilient mithral chainmail*, *+3 major striking greater shock wounding rapier*
Hungersense As gimmerling.

AC 47; **Fort** +36, **Ref** +39, **Will** +33
HP 374; **Weaknesses** cold iron 20
Thorny Aura (aura, primal, transmutation) 15 feet. Thorny roots and barbed vines writhe and twist in the aura, creating difficult hazardous terrain that inflicts 4d6 piercing damage whenever a non-flying creature moves within the aura.
Trip Up ↷ As gimmerling, but DC 44 and 3d10 bludgeoning damage on a failed save.

Speed 30 feet; trickster's step
Melee ❖ *rapier* +40 (deadly d8, disarm, finesse, magic), **Damage** 4d6+16 piercing plus 1d6 electricity and 1d6 bleed
Melee ❖ claw +37 (agile, finesse), **Damage** 4d6+16 slashing plus Disarm
Melee ❖ jaws +37 (finesse), **Damage** 4d8+16 plus 2d8 poison
Occult Innate Spells DC 44, attack +36; **10th** *alter reality*; **9th** *dispel magic, telepathic demand*; **8th** *disappearance, suggestion, uncontrollable dance*; **7th** *dimension door*, *heal*, *plane shift*, *teleport*; **Cantrips (10th)** *daze*, *message*, *shield*, *telekinetic projectile*
Change Shape ❖ (concentrate, polymorph, primal, transmutation) As gimmerling.
Disarm ❖❖ As gimmerling.
Sneak Attack Werendegar deals 4d6 extra precision damage to flat-footed creatures.
Trickster's Step As gimmerling, but Werendegar also avoids hazardous terrain.

A4. THE ROOF BRIDGE — TRIVIAL 20

A gap between two overgrown islands has been bridged here by a building that has partially collapsed into the void. Only the upper walls and wood-shingled roof of the building remains, forming a sort of bridge between the two islands. The steeply angled roofline makes crossing it a daunting task, even if one were to attempt to do so along the narrow roof beam across its center.

The roof bridge is stable, and can support any amount of weight, but it still remains a tricky way to move from the southern islands of the Market to the northern one. As anyone attempts to cross this "bridge," loose shingles slip, slippery patches of standing water or runny mold well up from the wood, and tiny vines growing on the building twist and grasp with lives of their own at those who cross. As a result of these conditions, a character can Climb across the sloped roofs with a DC 40 Athletics check or walk along the narrow beam by Balancing with a DC 40 Acrobatics check. A critical failure results in a fall, after which the character lands on the ground on the original side of the bridge they started from.

Creatures: The roof bridge is the lesser danger facing the PCs here, for a potentially familiar face lurks among the foliage just north of the roof. This is a lumbering fetch behemoth who wears the guise of the troll king Hargulka. He waits until the PCs are split between the two islands, preferably when at least one PC is still navigating the roof bridge, before he emerges from the trees with a roar to attack. He rolls Stealth for initiative, and his bellowing challenge alerts the vilderavns in area **A5** who join the battle at the start of the 3rd round (increasing this from a Trivial 20 encounter to a Severe 20 one).

HARGULKA FETCH — CREATURE 20

Fetch behemoth (page 613)
Initiative Stealth +36

A5. FRAGMENTED INN — MODERATE 20

This building is similar to the one at area **A3**, save that it appears as an inn the PCs frequented or built in their capital; inside, all that exists is the inn's foyer, with other doors that once provided access to additional rooms now simply providing exits or entrances to the inn itself.

Creatures: The Lantern King is served by many fey, but he particularly favors vilderavn heralds as his agents in the Stolen Lands—the PCs may have encountered one of them before as a random encounter in Thousand Voices. The three heralds posted here in this fragmented inn, though, are instead failures who are serving out penance as guards. The Lantern King has ordered them to slay the PCs if they attempt to reach this part of the Market, and he has promised all three heralds that they'll be allowed to return to their duties elsewhere if they succeed. As such, the vilderavns are eager to earn their freedom, and they fight to the death as soon as they notice the PCs (likely as a result of hearing a roar from the fetch behemoth at area **A4**).

VILDERAVN HERALDS (3) — CREATURE 19

See page 614
Initiative Perception +35

A6. CRUMBLING WORKSHOP — TRIVIAL 20

This large, roofless structure should be described to the PCs to remind them of a guildhall, library, laboratory, or other workshop that they built in their kingdom.

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It'd be best if the workshop itself was based on one in which one of the PCs spent time crafting magic items or otherwise Earning a Living over the course of the campaign to this point. Within, the roof is missing, but the PCs should find a fair amount of supplies and items that could be used as resources—see Treasure below.

Creature: While the Lantern King delights in testing the PCs' ability as they make their way up to his throne room, he also likes to think of himself as not being unfair—as someone who plays by the rules (even if the "rules" in this case are a collection of often self-contradicting whims). Setting up Werendegar as a "greeter" in area **A3** is one such concession to "playing fair," and Gribbler, a fetch stalker who takes the form of a redcap rather than of an NPC known by the PCs, is another. Gribbler's task is to welcome the PCs to the workshop, to inform them that he's here to provide what aid he can, and to show them that the workshop's contents are theirs to draw upon as they see fit. Gribbler explains that the PCs are free to spend as long as they wish here—but only as long as it takes for each of them to finish a single task. At your option, if the PCs attempt to game this system, Gribbler might grow impatient and attack. He does his best to be honest and friendly, and he'll even warn the PCs about the unstable flooring to the west if he thinks that aid will help earn the PCs' trust. Gribbler is true to his word in helping them with any tasks they perform here—he'll use the Aid reaction as you see fit—but that doesn't mean he's entirely forthright. The Lantern King has a constant telepathic link with Gribbler, and anything and everything the PCs say or do in his presence is immediately reported via this link. Gribbler tries to cover this up and becomes evasive if asked about his relationship with the Lantern King; if pressed on it, he shrieks in frustration and attacks rather than risk giving up the truth that he has been spying on the PCs.

GRIBBLER CREATURE 18

Fetch stalker (page 612)

Initiative Deception +36

Hazard: While the westernmost section of this building appears to be solid, if anyone walks on the floor there, it will collapse and fall away.

COLLAPSING FLOOR HAZARD 20

MECHANICAL TRAP

Stealth DC 48 (legendary)

Description The westernmost 5 feet of the building gives way, dropping rubble and anyone in the area into the depths of the Lantern Kingdom below.

Disable Thievery DC 51 to quickly jury-rig key supports against weak wall sections to prevent the collapse

Collapse ↷ **Trigger** A Small or larger creature walks into either 5-foot-square at the westernmost end of the building; **Effect** The triggering creature falls and takes 50 bludgeoning damage, then an additional 10d6 bludgeoning damage as they and the building's falling timbers "land" in a devastating crash at area **A1**. The creature can use the Grab an Edge reaction to avoid falling.

Treasure: This workshop can provide the PCs with supplies to retrain, craft magic items, or pursue one Downtime activity each while trapped in the Lantern Kingdom. The supplies found here are worth 75,000 gp in all; any items or retraining the PCs pursue uses this pool of gp, and once it's depleted, the workshop can no longer be used in this fashion. It's possible to transport these resources out of the Lantern Kingdom, but they're so bulky that it should take dozens of trips.

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A7. ASCENDING VINES

A thick tangle of vines rises upward at a steep angle to attach to a floating block of earth and stone a hundred feet overhead, ending at what appears to be an open doorway in the side of a stone building. Now and then, the vines seem to shiver or twist on their own, and flowers bloom and wilt at an unnerving pace along the length, as if time itself were an untrustworthy constant.

Despite their appearance, these vines can be ascended fairly easily by high-level characters—it's only a DC 20 Athletics check to Climb them. Characters who do so find themselves entering the Residence at area **B1**.

THE RESIDENCE

The second island area the PCs visit in their journey through the Lantern Kingdom is a modest, one-bedroom home referred to here as the Residence. This building should be based, if possible, on homes connected with the PCs—be it their current domiciles, homes they grew up in, or the like. Descriptions of rooms below (including the map of the area provided here) are bare-bones as a result; you should add in a few extra bits of flavor to each to drive home the fact that this structure is eerily familiar to each of them in different ways. The idea that one of their greatest enemies, King Irovetti, has "moved into their home" should not be lost on the PCs.

The Residence has one entrance (into area **B1**) but several exits that each reveal another overgrown island of ruined buildings; characters who emerge from the Residence through any of these step out into area **C1**.

B1. STOREROOM

Shelves along the walls of this storeroom are filled with all matter of strange, eclectic objects, all caked with a thick layer of dust. A door stands in both the east and west wall; to the north, a partially collapsed wall looms over the strange vista of this weird realm above a cascading tangle of vines that leads downward.

Each PC enters this room from the door to the west and immediately experiences a strange sense of déjà vu: the room feels familiar in a way that evokes their own childhood home. For one PC it might be the scent of a parent's cooking lingering in the air. For another it might be a familiar carving they left on a beam as a child. For a third it could be the way they accidentally bump their head on an annoying overhanging beam, just like they'd done countless times before as they entered the room through the doorway. Any PC who looks through the shelves immediately recognizes several objects from their home, many of which they may have thought were lost forever. These objects are mundane in nature, and a closer examination along with success at a DC 40 Perception check is enough to note strange disconnects between the object and memory, as if the item were reconstructed by someone operating from a detailed description but who never actually saw the original.

B2. MAIN HALL SEVERE 20

A dining table is the focal point in this large, open hall, sitting against the middle of the southern wall and surrounded by a half-dozen comfortable-looking wooden chairs. Doors are present in every direction but north, where an archway allows passage into the bedroom beyond. Shelves and display cabinets sit against the northern wall to either side of the archway.

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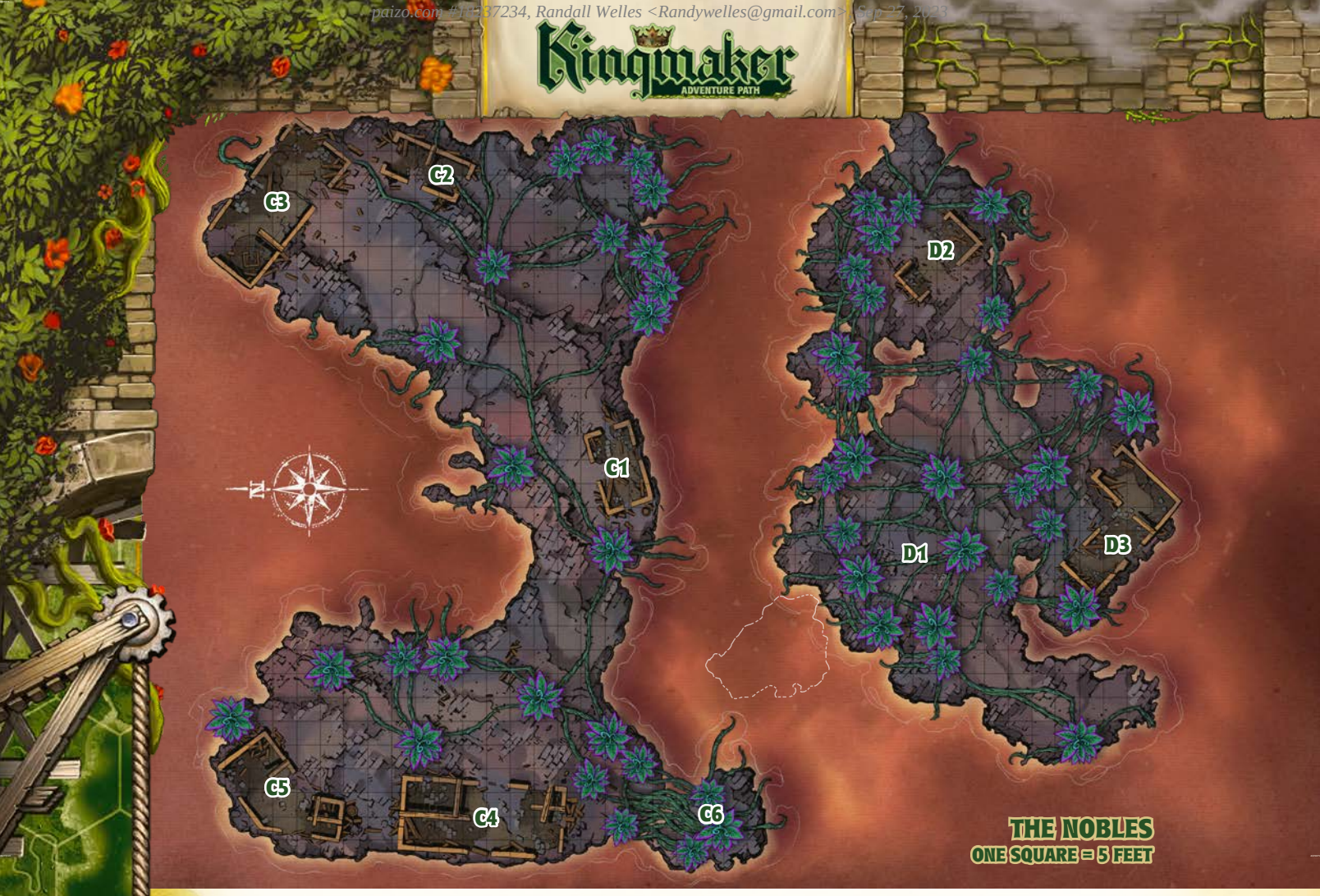

Elements in this room should evoke memories of living rooms and common areas in the PCs' homes.

The eastern double door provides an exit from the Residence into the Nobles isle.

Creatures: A "family" of four fetch stalkers dwells here. Each should resemble a family member of a different PC—perhaps a parent, a sibling, a cousin, or in the case of a PC who never knew their family, a friend or other NPC they've grown close to. The fetch stalkers welcome the PCs with a strange sense of delight and cheer, acting as if all of them being together in this strange manner isn't unusual at all. The fetch stalkers seek to have the PCs seated at the table, saying "dinner is about to be served" as they bustle about.

If the PCs comply, the fetches serve them fine food and drink, and you can play out this strange dinner party as long as you wish with the false family members giving nonsensical answers to the PCs when asked. Unless the PCs attack the fetches (in which case the fey shriek words like "betrayers" and "traitors" as they procure long fetch knives to fight back), their fetch family eventually reveals to them that the "master of the house" is joining them presently. A moment later, Castruccio Irovetti's fetch emerges from the private quarters (area **B4**) to attack, accusing the PCs of "stealing his home" and rolling Intimidation for his initiative. (If the PCs instigated the fight on their own, Irovetti's fetch joins the fight on the second round and rolls initiative using Perception instead.)

Irovetti's fetch manifests as a larger-than-life version of his previous incarnation—a towering, overly muscular creature nearly fourteen feet tall, dressed in rags and adorned with a crown that seems to grow from his skull rather than simply worn atop his head. His fetch weapon appears identical to a flaming version of his rod of razors, but it functions only as a fetch weapon, not the technological item he wielded in life.

FETCH STALKERS (4) CREATURE 18

See page 612

Initiative Perception +30

IROVETTI'S FETCH CREATURE 20

UNIQUE CE LARGE FEY

Variant fetch stalker (page 612)

Perception +36, darkvision

Languages Common, Sylvan; *tongues*

Skills Athletics +39, Deception +39, Intimidation +39, Society +32

Str +10, **Dex** +6, **Con** +9, **Int** +2, **Wis** +8, **Cha** +6

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AC 44; **Fort** +37, **Ref** +32, **Will** +34; +1 status to all saves vs. magic
HP 440, regeneration 45 (deactivated by fire or negative); **Weaknesses** cold iron 20, negative 20

Speed 35 feet, *air walk*
Melee ❖ fetch weapon +38 (backswing, magic, forceful); **Damage** 4d6+18 slashing plus 3d6 mental and 4d6 fire
Primal Innate Spells DC 40, attack +31; **10th** *finger of death*; **9th** *disjunction*; **7th** *plane shift* (to or from the First World only); **Cantrips (10th)** *produce flame*, *read aura*; **Constant (9th)** *air walk*, *tongues*
Manifest Fetch Weapon As fetch stalker (page 612), but with the alternate traits and flame damage detailed above in his melee Strike.

B3. KITCHEN

This fair-sized kitchen and pantry has a large stone washbasin next to a rain barrel, fed from a pipe coming out of the wall. The south wall has a large stone cooking hearth; ashen logs and soot spill from the opening and across the floor. Next to the fireplace rests a stack of neatly chopped firewood. Hooks on the walls hold an assortment of pots, spoons, ladles and other cookware.

The double door to the west provides an exit from the Residence, as do the ones to the east and south.

Treasure: When the Lantern King drew upon dreams and memories harvested from the PCs and their legacy, not everything became weaponized against them—there were some unanticipated side effects, such as those found in this room.

Any PC who enters the kitchen experiences a feeling of protection and safety, be it in the form of warm memories of loving parents, the support of a deity, or simply recollections of old friendships. These feelings automatically draw each PC to an item of food or drink in the kitchen they instinctively recognize as a cherished meal from childhood. Whatever the form of this meal, the PC also understands immediately upon touching the meal that it functions as an elixir of rejuvenation.

B4. PRIVATE QUARTERS

This room appears to have been the bedchamber of someone who, while once rich, has fallen on hard times. A rickety bed covered with ratty, once regal sheets extends from the far wall. A chest sits at the foot of the bed, the padlock hanging open from its latch tantalizingly, while a nightstand, an ornately carved but dilapidated wardrobe, and an elegantly shaped but wobbly wooden chair sit to the sides. The room exudes a sense of forlorn nostalgia, as if memory itself is trapped here.

As the PCs look through this bedroom, they should recognize a few things from their home (be it current or childhood), but these objects have been broken, vandalized, or otherwise ruined by Irovetti's Fetch. The PCs encounter him here if they somehow manage to avoid attracting his attention in area **B2**. The door to the west provides an exit from the residence (page 491).

Treasure: The chest at the foot of the bed is unlocked, and within is a large misshapen object fashioned from metal and glass, radiating a pale golden glow. This is one of the three shards of the *Apology*: the chalice stem. The shard is Bulk 1, and if the PCs learned of the shards from Werendegar, they automatically recognize it for what it is. Otherwise, success on a DC 40 check to Identify Magic reveals the truth.

THE NOBLES

Reaching the Nobles island is a simple matter of exiting the Residence through any of its doors or windows. When the PCs do so, they emerge from area **C1**.

This island is based on whichever part of the PCs' capital is inhabited by the most nobles and aristocrats. The open area between the ruined manors to the north and south is strewn with bodies and bears obvious signs of recent combat. The bodies resemble allies, friends, and recognizable citizens from the PCs' capital, but they're little more than decoration; success at a DC 35 Nature check confirms that the "corpses" are in fact cleverly cultivated plants that have been grown into shapes resembling bodies.

The Lantern King set this area up to create a mock clash between an ally and an enemy of the PCs: Lady Jamandi and Vordakai. In fact, both are fetches who seek to toy with the PCs before killing them off.

C1. DILAPIDATED HOME

Regardless of the method the PCs use to exit the Residence, they do so as if stepping through a partially ruined doorframe on the west face of what appears to be a partially collapsed house. Even a cursory inspection of this house reveals that it seems to be a ruined version of a childhood home, appearing differently to each viewer. A character who enters this house at any point finds themselves returning to area **B2** in the Residence.

Unless the PCs take pains to remain stealthy when they arrive, they'll be spotted by "allies" to the north who quickly call out their names and wave them over toward areas **C2** and **C3**.

C2. COLLAPSED OUTBUILDING LOW 20

This collapsed building looks to have once been a groundskeeper's cottage, but little remains today save for crumbled timbers.

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Creatures: Three fetch stalkers hunker down here, apparently watching to the south for any advance from their "enemies" in areas **C4** and **C5**. In fact, they're waiting to call out to the PCs. These three fetches should appear as friendly NPCs the PCs know from the Stolen Lands—good choices for identities might include Oleg and Svetlana Leveton, or even Maegar Varn or another now deceased ally, but feel free to swap these out for other NPCs the PCs have grown close to.

The three fetches appear grateful but worried as they approach the PCs. Unless they're immediately attacked, they explain that they've been drawn into this strange world and pitted against none other than Vordakai, back from the dead. The fetches claim to have been clashing with his forces for days, and only a few friendly survivors remain holed up in the nearby manor. The fetches attempt to lead the PCs to area **C3** to meet their commander, but if the PCs instead attack, those stationed in area **C3** come here to join the fight 1d4 rounds after combat begins.

FETCH STALKERS (3) CREATURE 18

See page 612
Initiative Perception +30

C3. RUINED MANOR TRIVIAL 20

Only the facade and part of the entry hall of this once-great manor remains standing, the rest of it appearing to have collapsed into the void below.

Add a few additional bits of description to this ruined manor so that the PCs recognize it as Lady Jamandi's manor house; the fact that it's incongruously located in what pretends to be the PCs' capital is yet another awkward element of the Lantern Kingdom's imperfect attempt to mimic a postapocalyptic Stolen Lands kingdom.

Creatures: Another two fetch stalkers wait here, having staged a scene they hope will help the PCs waste some of their resources. The two fetches appear to be friendly NPCs—if you're using the *Kingmaker Companion Guide*, choose some from that book who haven't accompanied the PCs; otherwise, these two fetches should appear to be Ioseph Sellemius and Ivenzi, whom the PCs met in Lady Jamandi's manor at the start of this campaign.

The two fetches appear to be attending a third figure—a very badly wounded Lady Jamandi, who lies beaten and bloodied on a table. The fetches beg the PCs for aid in healing her. In truth, "Lady Jamandi" is an *illusory creature* cast by one of the two fetches. They hope to trick the PCs into depleting some of their healing reserves on Lady Jamandi, who "wakes" from the healing after a few rounds. If the PCs don't see through the ruse, the illusory Jamandi urges them to accompany her and her remaining allies south to strike at Vordakai, whom she claims "just recently had to retreat after our last fight—we should strike at him before he recovers!"

If the PCs fall for the ruse, the fetch stalkers from here and area **C2** lead the PCs south to area **C4**, and once a fight begins there, they aid the PCs for a few rounds before turning on them and siding with the "enemy." In any event, the fetch stalkers are quick to switch to combat as soon as they suspect the PCs have seen through their ruse.

FETCH STALKERS (2) CREATURE 18

See page 612
Initiative Perception +30

C4. SUNDERED STABLES LOW 20

A sprawling wooden stable sits at the edge of this overgrown island, but its once fine features have been sullied with blood, mud, and filth. The roof remains mostly intact, but here and there portions have fallen away into rubble within.

Creatures: While these stables may have been used to house prize horses in the Material Plane version of the building, here it houses two immense monstrosities—primal bandersnatches. These massive, six-legged, catlike creatures hide amid the rubble and beams near the building's roof. As soon as the PCs approach within 15 feet of the building, the two emerge to attack, rolling Stealth for initiative. The sound of their eerie roars is certainly enough to draw "Vordakai" from area **C5**, who joins the fight at the start of the second round.

PRIMAL BANDERSNATCHES (2) CREATURE 19

See page 610
Initiative Stealth +33

C5. DESTROYED MANSION MODERATE 20

Only a fragment of one wing survives of what may have once been a glorious, sprawling mansion. Its southwestern face slumps in rubble over the void, while the facade that remains is riddled with holes and splattered with gore.

Feel free to add additional elements to the above description to make the PCs recognize this ruined mansion as a location close to them, be it the sprawling manor of an NPC ally or one of their own residences found within their capital.

Creatures: A single deadly occupant lies in wait in this destroyed mansion: a risen fetch based on the

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cyclops wizard Vordakai. As with all risen fetches, this creature appears as Vordakai did in life, not as he did in undeath—his eye remains intact and his body is hearty and healthy in appearance, yet the PCs should be able to recognize him with ease. Unlike most of the other fetches encountered in the Lantern Kingdom, Vordakai's fetch has no agenda of trickery; he waits here patiently, hoping the fetches to the north will successfully lead the PCs toward him so that a glorious betrayal will occur. If the PCs instead confront him first, he does his best to use flashy, impossible-to-ignore spell effects and works his way north to draw in the fetches from areas **C2** and **C3**.

Vordakai's fetch is Large, but his stats otherwise conform exactly to those presented for the risen fetch on page 613.

VORDAKAI'S FETCH CREATURE 22

UNIQUE CE LARGE FEY

Variant risen fetch (page 613)

Initiative Perception +38

Treasure: Vordakai's fetch carries a shard of the *Apology* in a pocket of his robes; when he's slain and his remains decay away, this fractured portion of the chalice's cup remains behind. As with the previous shard, this shard is Bulk 1; it can be recognized in the same way as the shard in area **B4**.

C6. THE RISING ROCK

A smaller slab of rock, its surface overgrown with plants, visibly bobs in the air here, tethered to the larger, more stable island to the west via a thick tangle of vines. Now and then, the vines twitch and move, as if they were enjoying the act of clutching this rock, or perhaps straining to keep it in place

This smaller isle can be used to ascend 100 feet to the Park above. To do so, the vines anchoring it to the Nobles must be destroyed. The vines themselves are numerous but individually easy to break. A minute or so of work is all that's needed, after which point this islet rises up to the area indicated on the map by the dotted outline adjacent to area **D1**. The islet remains for 1 minute before it sinks back down to this location and the vines reattach it to the Nobles.

THE PARK

This island features only two buildings; most of its expanse is a riotous tangle of wildflowers, trees, brambles, fungi, and the like. If the PCs had a park or similar area in their capital, adjust descriptions here and there to make it apparent this region is based on their park. Alternately, if one of the PCs has particularly fond memories of a wilderness location in the Stolen Lands, features from that location might have been pulled in to this tangle as well. Feel free to adjust the overall size and shape of this island if you need more room to integrate a wilderness location like this, or even to attach a map of such an area, such as the Temple of the Elk, to the region.

VORDAKAI'S FETCH

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D1. SNICKERSNACK SEVERE 20

Here, the sprawling tangle of rampant overgrowth rules completely. No sign of civilization is apparent on this isle save for a looming monument glimpsed through trees to the north and brief glimpses of some sort of structure through the overgrowth to the east.

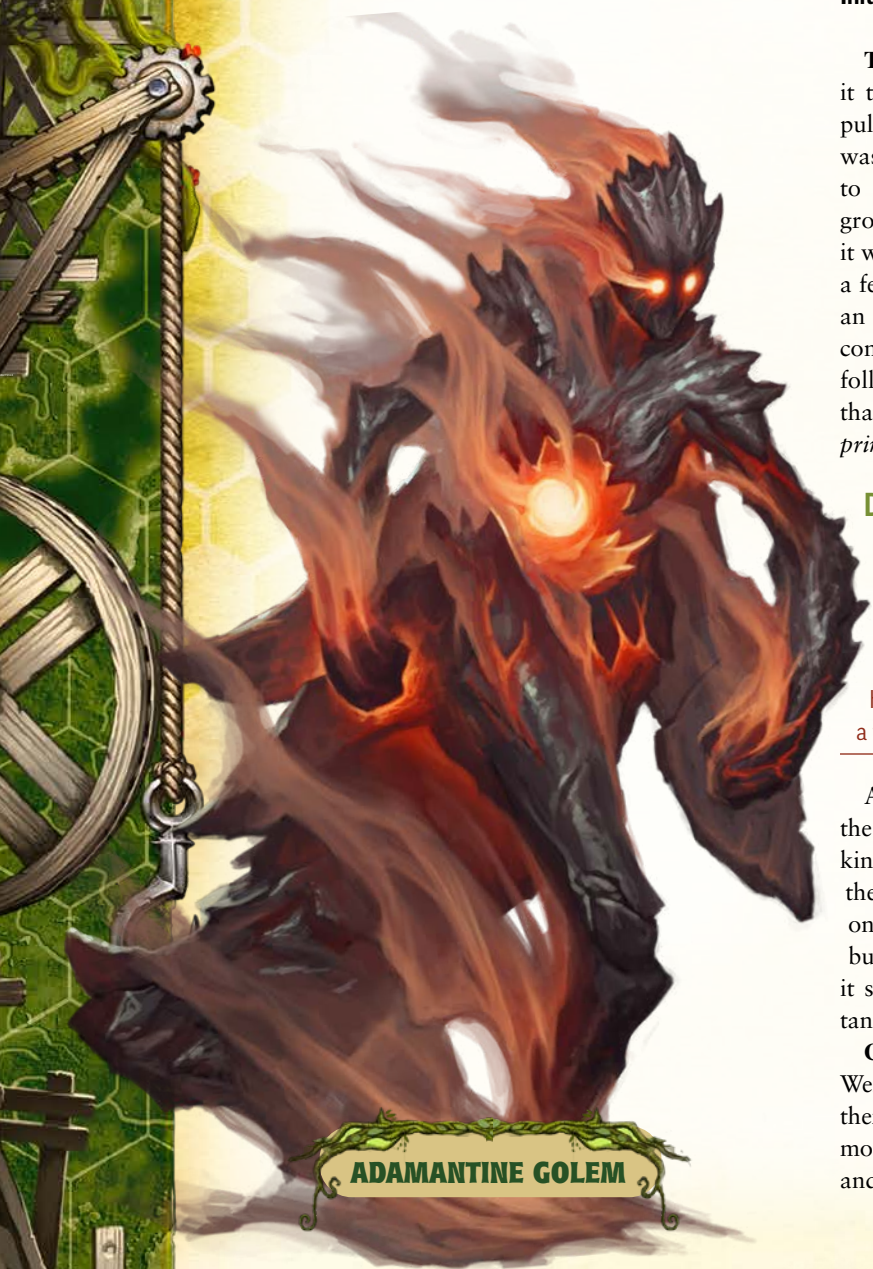
The significant overgrowth on this island outside of the two ruined buildings functions as greater difficult terrain. Worse, the edges of this island consist of mats of deceptive vegetation that hang out over the gulf below. A character who enters any space shared by the island's edge must make a successful DC 35 Reflex save upon entering that space or plunge through the vegetation into a fall, landing a moment later in the space they left before stepping into nothingness.

Creatures: The most dangerous foe the PCs face in the Park is a jabberwock. The immense Tane stomps and burbles and patrols this entire region; it immediately attacks the PCs as soon as it notices them. As the jabberwock moves, the surrounding vegetation parts for its approach as if fearful of its arrival; as such, the jabberwock ignores the greater difficult terrain caused by this island.

JABBERWOCK CREATURE 23

Pathfinder Bestiary 2 150
Initiative Perception +40

Treasure: As soon as the PCs slay the jabberwock, it thrashes and crashes as it expires, coughing up a pulsing mass of tissue as it does so; if the jabberwock was defeated via an effect like *disintegrate* or banished to another plane, the mass of tissue drops to the ground in one of the squares the Tane occupied before it was defeated. The tissue rots away quickly, revealing a few notable treasures in its passing—a *third eye* and an orichalcum scroll tube (itself worth 2,500 gp) that contains a single scroll (this scroll contains one of the following 10th-level spells, chosen from a tradition that at least one PC can cast: *alter reality*, *miracle*, *primal phenomenon*, or *wish*).



D2. MONUMENT LOW 20

A towering but badly eroded monument stands atop a rectangular base here, towering above the surrounding trees. Just beyond the monument to the north, a stump of land extends toward the region's highest island floating above. Atop this last island stands a familiar-looking structure.

Adjust the monument's description to match the largest or most notable monument in the PCs' kingdom—if none exist, it is instead a monument to the kingdom's ruler. The "familiar-looking structure" on the upper island is recognizable as the PCs' capital building, be it a castle, a palace, or whatever, save that it seems to be in a crumbling state of disrepair with tangles of ivy growing along its walls.

Creature: Unless the PCs defeated him earlier, Werendegar retreats to this location after speaking to them in area **A3**. He waits patiently, seated atop the monument's stone base, biding his time with a drink and a book (success on a DC 25 Perception check reveals that the book is *Zuddiger's Picnic*). Once Werendegar spots the PCs, he tosses

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the drink and book aside—they promptly vanish in puffs of smoke—and he calls out to the characters asking if they've gathered up the *Apology*. If not, he shakes his head in disappointment and waves them off to finish the task.

If they've gathered all three shards, he claps in delight and hops down from the monument, beckoning for the PCs to follow him north to area **D4**. If the PCs attack him, he flees via *dimension door* to the Palace's throne room, leaving the PCs to find their own way forward.

WERENDEGAR CREATURE 21

See page 488

Initiative Perception +35

D3. THE HOUSE BEYOND TIME MODERATE 20

Fragments of a familiar structure—the House at the Edge of Time—stand at the edge of this island. Most of the building appears to have crumbled away, but what remains of the partially collapsed ruin is still recognizable as having once been part of Nyrissa's home in Thousandbreaths.

All that remains of Nyrissa's home is an L-shaped fragment missing most of its roof. Within, among the rubble (which functions only as difficult terrain, rather than the surrounding park's greater difficult terrain), bits and pieces of the finery and decor from the nymph queen's home remain, but little of value can be scavenged from the destruction.

Creature: Amid the rubble stand what appear to be three 8-foot-tall adamantine statues vaguely similar in appearance to Nyrissa. In truth, these are smaller-than-normal adamantine golems powered by the Lantern King's own fury. While these golems are only Medium size, their statistics are those of elite adamantine golems, except that their attacks lack the normal 15-foot reach of a typical adamantine golem. Once the golems notice the PCs, fires flare up inside them and they all move to attack, plumes of smoke and flickers of flame churning in their hollow torsos or red-hot eye sockets. The three golems pursue foes relentlessly through the Park; as with the jabberwock, the writhing tangles of vegetation part for them as they advance, allowing the golems to ignore the greater difficult terrain (they do not ignore the difficult terrain inside of this ruined building).

ELITE ADAMANTINE GOLEMS (3) CREATURE 18

RARE | N | MEDIUM | CONSTRUCT | GOLEM | MINDLESS

Pathfinder Bestiary 6, 188

Initiative Perception +28

Melee ❖ fist +37 (deadly 3d12, magical), **Damage** 3d10+19 bludgeoning plus destructive strike

Treasure: Success at a DC 40 Perception check made while Searching the ruins of this structure uncovers a shard of a chalice's cup—this is the third and final shard of the *Apology*, which can be recognized as detailed in area **B4**.

D4. PALACE APPROACH

Once the PCs have all three shards of the *Apology*, they can readily see how the pieces of the vessel fit back together and reassemble it. If the reassembled *Apology* is brought to this location, the ground shakes and trembles as the world the Lantern King has made bursts into wisps of translucent shadow, forming and racing like a raging torrent back into the *Apology*. Again the world starts to shift, slowly as if it straining to decide which direction to go. A mass of animated vines and rubble suddenly surges forward from this spot, rising through the mists to form a winding spiral ramp that leads upward to the final isle above: the Palace.

THE PALACE

If the PCs follow the winding pathway up to the Palace from area **D4**, they arrive before a double door that opens automatically as they approach, allowing them to enter the throne room beyond. If the PCs reach these doors via other methods, such as via flight, the doors are locked tight. A DC 50 Thievery check can Pick the Lock, or a DC 50 Athletics check can Force them Open, but the doors themselves instantly heal damage inflicted to them. At your option, other powerful effects such as *wish* can open the doors. Teleportation effects can allow the PCs to enter the chamber beyond, as can spells like *passwall*, but unless they have multiple uses of this magic, doing so might simply end up trapping the PCs within the throne room with no escape route.

The sprawling throne room beyond the doors should be described as the same as the PCs' own throne room back on the Material Plane, except in a devastating state of ruin.

Cracks radiate along the floor and walls of the throne room, while what appear to be perpetual fires burn along pillars and walls without consuming the structure. The thrones to the east look to be partially melted as if from some unimaginable heat, while vines of weird plants festooned with colorful flowers grow here and there as if nature itself were in the process of reclaiming the room.

This encounter takes place entirely within the throne room; you should adjust the map to match the PCs' throne room as needed. The rooms bordering this throne room are mostly for show—the doors should be difficult or even impossible to open unless you wish to expand this map for your game's climactic battle.

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Creatures: The Lantern King is a demigod, and as such is far too powerful a foe to face directly. Fortunately for the PCs, they won't need to face him in person; the Lantern King has created a manifestation of his power within this room, an avatar of sorts, through whom he looks forward to speaking to the PCs. Initially, he appears in the form of a handsome, slender fey man with pointed ears and crown-like horns on his head. His armor and weapons evoke themes of a lit, glowing lantern, but all of this is merely for show; if a fight begins, he assumes his natural form—that of a 25-foot-diameter sphere of fire and light surrounded by twisting magical runes.

The Lantern King irreverently sits on one of the melted thrones, waiting for the PCs to arrive. He is attended by a number of fetch stalkers, each of whom has the form of one of the PCs (as such, the number of fetch stalkers in attendance should equal the number of PCs in the encounter). These fetch stalkers kneel to either side of the throne, obviously submissive to the Lantern King in mockery of the PCs themselves.

If Werendegar escorts the PCs, he takes his time introducing each of them to the Lantern King. You should take the time to call out two significant accomplishments for each PC at this time, making it seem almost like Werendegar is bragging about the PCs to the Lantern King, but once he has completed his introductions, he turns to the PCs and says "Yet despite your accomplishments, you are but ashes before the glory of a god," before introducing the Lantern King himself. Werendegar then steps forward to take a silent position at the Lantern King's side.

The Lantern King is frustrated that the PCs have disrupted the long, complex torments he'd put in place for Nyrissa, but a part of him has to admit that watching them grow in power and succeed against the nymph queen has been almost as entertaining. He hopes to draw some final fun from the PCs in this encounter, and perhaps even recruit them as his agents.

This encounter resolves over the course of three different stages—Introductions, Apologies, and Invitations. During each of these stages, the PCs interact with the Lantern King by attempting different skill checks to build up Victory Points to determine the final outcome of this climactic resolution to the *Kingmaker Adventure Path*. The PCs are free to throw caution to the wind and attack the Lantern King at any point, but if they do so before completing the three stages, they'll face a much more dangerous fight. The Lantern King subtly encourages the PCs to lose

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their temper in the way he addresses them, hoping for a chance to test his avatar's mettle against the heroes of the Stolen Lands.

In each of the three stages, each PC has a chance to attempt a single skill check to build up their total number of Victory Points. The amount of points they earn for each check follows this default scale:

Critical Success The PCs gain 2 Victory Points.
Success The PCs gain 1 Victory Point.
Critical Failure The PCs lose 1 Victory Point.

INTRODUCTIONS

Even if Werendegar escorted them into the throne room, the Lantern King is eager to hear from the PCs themselves about who they are and why they have come before him. He starts this stage with the following comment and challenge.

"You come before me as heroes of your world, yet you are still children before me. Tell me, each of you, what great deed have you accomplished that would suggest that my time is worth being spent entertaining you?"

At this point, each of the PCs has a chance to boast about what they feel is their greatest deed throughout the course of this campaign. Each can choose any skill of their choice to perform this boast, provided they justify its use. Since the skills used in the next two stages are specific ones, this is a chance for characters with other specialties to shine. Once all of the PCs have boasted, the Lantern King claps slowly in an almost mocking way, then goes on to claim responsibility for the PCs' triumphs. After all, had he not set these events in motion by exiling Nyrissa, the PCs themselves would have had no "grand adventure" to become the heroes of.

Regardless of the skill chosen, it's a DC 42 check to earn Victory Points.

APOLOGIES

The second stage begins with the Lantern King saying the following.

"Long ago, Nyrissa insulted the Eldest with her arrogance and pride, and so we punished her. Yet we are not without mercy. I bade her replace the thousand slights she put upon us with a thousand kingdoms drawn from a thousand worlds. Once the task was done, I would have accepted her apology and would have granted those thousand kingdoms eternal glory as part of a greater world than their own. Yet you ruined this. It strikes me that now, this final apology falls upon you to offer me. Do you regret meddling in my affairs, mortals? Will each of you apologize for tampering with events beyond your reckoning?

The Lantern King expects each PC to answer. He doesn't necessarily expect an actual apology, although humility in this regard is an easier solution overall. As each PC replies, decide whether that character is honestly apologizing (and should therefore attempt a DC 35 Diplomacy check), offering a dishonest or evasive apology (in which case they attempt a DC 40 Deception check), or refusing to apologize or demanding the Lantern King apologize for his actions instead (which necessitates a DC 45 Intimidation check). The Lantern King is amused by evasions and threats in this stage, but it's tougher than simply apologizing to successfully entertain him that way.

INVITATIONS

Finally, the Lantern King raises a hand to his chin as he appears to consider his next words for a moment. After that moment, he speaks.

"You are each certainly notable and impressive mortals, I'll give you that. But you are limited by your own nature. Behold, then, my magnanimity: cast aside your petty nation and join my side as my servants, and you shall become legends not just in your own paltry realm, but throughout all of reality itself!"

The Lantern King won't reveal more of what he offers the PCs if they join his cause, and regardless of how the PCs react, they'll each need to decide how they want to frame their answers to him: respectfully (with a Diplomacy check), aggressively (with an Intimidation check), or deceitfully (with a Deception check). Regardless, it's a DC 40 check to earn Victory Points.

RESOLVING THE CONVERSATION

If the PCs make it through all three stages of the conversation without attacking the Lantern King, take a moment to total up their Victory Points to determine their overall success.

If the PCs earned a total number of Victory Points equal to or greater than the number of PCs, then the Lantern King is impressed by them. More importantly, the fetch stalkers he keeps at his side that take their appearances from the PCs take note and realize that they are mere shadows of the PCs' glory, and they do not join the Lantern King in the battle to come.

If the PCs earned fewer Victory Points than the number of PCs, the Lantern King cannot hold back his derision. He mocks the PCs' failure with a barrage of insults and laughter that continues for 2 rounds. If the PCs attack him during these two rounds, he's startled enough by their sudden bravery that he rolls for Initiative with a flat check.

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